



CITY: Pg 3

Delhi govt to fuse hospitals into AIIMS-style giant



NATION: Pg 7

Oppn accuses CEC of acting under 'thumb of executive'



FILM: Pg 12

'I wanted to step out of my comfort zone with Subedaar'

PM chairs CCS meeting, maps steps to secure food, fuel, energy supplies

Reviews impact of conflict, orders coordinated response to cushion fallout

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Cabinet Committee on Security on Sunday carried out a comprehensive review of the situation arising from the ongoing conflict in West Asia, assessing its implications for India's economy and the availability of essential commodities. The high-level meeting, chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, focused on ensuring uninterrupted access to food, fuel and energy for citizens while preparing both immediate and long-term responses to the evolving crisis.

According to an official statement, the prime minister directed the creation of a dedicated group of ministers and senior officials to adopt a whole-of-government



Prime Minister Narendra Modi chairs a high-level meeting to review the situation related to petroleum, crude, gas, power, and fertiliser sectors in view of the evolving West Asia situation

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Short, medium and long-term measures to ensure continued availability of essential needs discussed in detail
- » Alternate sources of fertilisers for farmers were also discussed to ensure continued availability in the future

- » Several measures discussed to diversify sources of imports required by chemicals, pharmaceuticals, petrochemicals and other industrial sectors

- » New export destinations to promote Indian goods to be developed in near future
- » PM instructs that all arms of government should work together to ensure least inconvenience to citizens

approach in handling the fallout of the conflict. The aim is

to coordinate responses across sectors and minimise disruption

tion to daily life.

Continued on P4

Govt directs faster processing of city gas projects, hikes commercial LPG

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The government has accelerated measures to improve gas distribution and address supply concerns, pushing for faster approvals of city gas projects while raising commercial LPG allocations for key sectors.

In a move aimed at speeding up infrastructure rollout, the Petroleum and Explosives

Continued on P4

US, IRAN TRADE THREATS

Iran says Hormuz will be 'completely closed' if Trump attacks power plants

ASSOCIATED PRESS

TEHRAN/ ARAD (ISRAEL): Iran has warned of retaliatory attacks on regional infrastructure if US President Donald Trump follows through on his ultimatum over the Strait of Hormuz.

Trump has said he will "obliterate" Iran's power plants if it fails to fully reopen the Strait of Hormuz within 48 hours.

"We have repeatedly said the Strait of Hormuz is closed only to the enemy and to harmful traffic," said army spokesman Ebrahim Zolfagari on state television, according to a report on Al Jazeera network on Sunday.

"It has not yet been completely closed and is under our intelligent control and harmless transit - under specific regulations that ensure our security and interests - is allowed, the spokesman said. Separately, Iranian officials said they would keep providing safe passage through the strait to vessels from countries other than its enemies.

"However, if the United States carries out its threats against Iran's power plants the following punitive actions will be taken immediately:

- The Strait of Hormuz will be completely closed and will not reopen until our damaged power plants are rebuilt.
- All power plants and the energy and information technology infrastructure of Israel will be widely targeted.
- All similar companies in



IRAN WARNS

- » The Strait of Hormuz will be completely closed and will not reopen until our damaged power plants are rebuilt
- » All power plants and the energy and information technology infrastructure of Israel

will be widely targeted.

- » All similar companies in the region that have American shareholders will be completely destroyed

- » Power plants in regional countries hosting US bases will be considered legitimate targets

the region that have American shareholders will be completely destroyed.

- Power plants in regional countries hosting US bases will be considered legitimate targets."

Meanwhile, the Lebanese militant group Hezbollah, stepped up their attacks on Israel on Sunday, launching strikes across the country after the US and Iran threatened to widen their targets in the war in the Middle East, now in its fourth week.

As Israel came under renewed fire, top Israeli leaders

travelled to the southern town of Arad, one of two communities near a secretive nuclear research site struck by Iranian missiles late Saturday, wounding scores of people.

Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu toured the destruction in Arad and said it was a "miracle" no one was killed there. He claimed Israel and the US were well on their way to achieving the war's goals and explored the international community for more support.

Earlier, President Trump warned the US will destroy Iran's

Continued on P4

Russian oil tanker diverted from China reaches India

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A Russian oil tanker diverted from China has reached India's west coast, marking the first of several such vessels being rerouted amid global supply disruptions triggered by the ongoing West Asia conflict and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

The medium-range tanker

Aqua Titan, chartered by Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd, arrived off the Mangaluru coast on Sunday and is currently stationed about 10 nautical miles, or roughly 18.5 km, offshore, awaiting unloading through offshore facilities. According to ship-tracking data, the Cameroon-flagged vessel reached New Mangalore

Continued on P4

Over half of countries have banned phones in schools, claims UNESCO

NEW DELHI: A growing number of countries are restricting mobile phone use in schools, with more than half now enforcing national bans, according to UNESCO's Global Education Monitoring report, as concerns deepen over classroom distraction and online harm.

The report states that 114 education systems, account-

TAKEAWAYS

- » 114 education systems now enforce national school phone bans, covering 58 per cent of countries

- » Share of bans rose from 24 per cent in 2023 to 40 per

cent in 2025

- » By March 2026, global coverage increased by nearly 20 percentage points

- » UNESCO links bans to declining classroom attention and rising cyberbullying concerns

bans on phones in schools. The rise has

Continued on P4



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MARCH 25 TO 31

Delhi to host 1st International Film Fest

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi is set to host its first international film festival from March 25 to 31, with more than 140 films from 47 countries to be screened across multiple venues in the national capital.

The International Film Festival of Delhi (IFFD) 2026 will feature free public screenings, discussions, workshops and cultural programmes, according to a statement.

Several prominent figures from Indian and international cinema, including Vicky Kaushal, Hema Malini, Bhumi Pednekar, Rana Daggubati and Madhur Bhandarkar, are

expected to participate in the week-long event.

The festival will open at Bharat Mandapam with a red carpet ceremony hosted by Arjun Kapoor and Nimrat Kaur. Actors Anupam Kher, Sanya Malhotra and Siddhant Chaturvedi will also attend the opening evening, which will include a gala screening of the Oscar-nominated film *Sirat*.

Screenings will be held at Bharat Mandapam, PVR-INOX theatres and other public venues across the city, with select shows also planned at outdoor locations and mobile screening units to widen access to cinema, the statement said. International features, documentaries, short films, animation and restored classics will



Screenings will be held at Bharat Mandapam, PVR-INOX theatres and other public venues across the city

TAKEAWAYS

» The festival will open at Bharat Mandapam with a red carpet ceremony hosted by Arjun Kapoor & Nimrat Kaur

» Actors Anupam Kher, Sanya Malhotra and Siddhant Chaturvedi will also attend the opening

» The festival will host masterclasses and in-conversation sessions with film personalities

ive marking the birth centenary of filmmaker Guru Dutt, a restored 4K version of *Pyaasa* will be screened.

Selections from partner festivals, including the Singapore International Film Festival, will also be showcased, along with post-screening discussions and interactions with filmmakers.

The festival will host masterclasses and in-conversation sessions with film personalities, such as Manoj Bajpayee, Boman Irani, Imtiaz Ali and Shekhar Kapur, offering audiences an opportunity to engage directly with industry professionals. Workshops focusing on filmmaking and storytelling

will also be organised, it added.

An industry platform, IFFD CineXchange, will run alongside the public events, bringing together filmmakers, producers, distributors and OTT platforms through curated labs, co-production markets and project showcases.

Public registrations for the festival are now open, with entry to screenings and events subject to prior booking and venue capacity, the statement added.

The festival is organised by the Delhi Tourism and Transportation Development Corporation (DTTDC) in association with the Delhi government.

Illegal adoption racket busted, infant rescued in Gr Noida

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GREATER NOIDA: A 10-day-old premature baby girl was rescued by a Child Helpline (1098) team from an alleged illegal adoption racket operating out of a private hospital in Greater Noida West, officials said on Sunday. Four people, including the hospital owner and two staff members, have been detained, and an investigation is underway.

The infant, born at 33 weeks, was abandoned at a private facility in the Bisrakh area earlier this month. She remained at the hospital, where she was allegedly offered for sale under the guise of adoption.

The case surfaced when a man approached the Child Helpline office in Noida after receiving an "offer" for a newborn while searching online for legal adoption procedures. He told officials he was promised a baby for Rs 2.7 lakh along with forged documents, including a birth certificate. Authorities alerted the police and persuaded him to assist in a sting operation.

A joint team comprising the Child Helpline, Anti-Human Trafficking Unit (AHTU), Child Welfare Committee (CWC) and Bisrakh police laid a trap. On Saturday evening, the complainant met the suspects near Bisrakh round-



about. Two hospital employees, including a nurse, arrived with the infant, whereupon plainclothes officers intervened and detained them.

Central Noida DCP Shakti Awasthi said the woman carrying the baby was apprehended around 4:30 pm. "During interrogation, the duo allegedly revealed they were acting on instructions from the hospital owner." Police subsequently detained the owner, identified as Yashika Garg, along with two others — Gajendra, a sanitation worker, and Ranjit, an operation theatre technician.

Police suspect a wider network, with preliminary inputs indicating similar transactions in the past, where infants were allegedly sold for up to Rs 5 lakh. Efforts are underway to trace the baby's biological parents and ascertain the circumstances of her abandonment, the DCP added. The rescued infant has been shifted to a shelter facility under the CWC and is reported to be stable.

‘Insider tip-off’ led to Rs 23L gunpoint robbery, 3 arrested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Three men were arrested for allegedly robbing a transport company employee of Rs 23 lakh at gunpoint near Shastri Nagar Metro station in north Delhi, police said on Sunday.

They said the robbery was executed at an insider tip-off.

On February 23, Kuldeep Sharma, 28, collected the cash from Keshav Puram and was returning to his office in Kishanganj on a motorcycle.

Around 7.40 pm, two men on a motorcycle intercepted him near the metro station, pointed a gun at him, and fled with the cash bag, the police said. CCTV footage showed that the two robbers had been following Sharma all along, with a third separating midway. He was later identified as

Kalaram, a Rajasthan native, who remains at large, the police said. The police arrested one of the riders, 31-year-old Monu, from Bhalswa Dairy on March 9, with a pistol, a live cartridge, and Rs 3.95 lakh in cash on him.

"Monu and the absconding accused had planned the robbery after receiving information about the movement of cash. He also arranged the weapon and the motorcycle used in the crime," an officer said.

Based on Monu's confession, police arrested Sandeep (39) in Mangolpuri on March 19, recovering Rs 5 lakh. Another accused, Sagar (30), was also held, with Rs 7 lakh seized. In total, Rs 15.95 lakh has been recovered, while efforts continue to nab others.

QUIET COMPANIONS



A pair of pigeons perch on a tree branch, in New Delhi, on Sunday. PTI

NOIDA: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday inspected the Noida International Airport to review preparations for its inauguration by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on March 28, officials said. The chief minister also carried out an on-site inspection of arrangements for the inauguration ceremony and later held a review meeting with public representatives and senior officials, issuing necessary directives.



The inauguration of the airport and its cargo terminal, along with the foundation stone laying for a maintenance, repair and operations (MRO) facility, is scheduled to be per-

formed by the prime minister on March 28.

According to an official statement, during the inspection, Adityanath reviewed the route designated for the

prime minister's visit and examined key locations, including the passenger terminal, cargo terminal, rally venue, parking areas, access routes and helipad.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath reviewed inauguration preparations, directing seamless arrangements, strong security and infrastructure, and extensive branding to ensure a well-planned, large-scale event with adequate public facilities. PTI

LPG hoarders nabbed with 74 cylinders in Mahipalpur

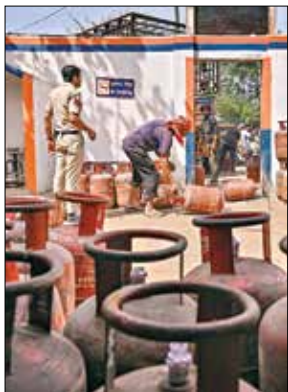
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Three men were arrested in southwest Delhi's Mahipalpur for allegedly hoarding LPG cylinders to sell them at a premium price, police said on Sunday.

They were identified as Krishna, Dinesh Sahu, and Mithilesh, aged 33, 46, and 39, all from Bihar but living in Delhi. The police seized 74 LPG cylinders — 70 domestic and four commercial — along with a transport vehicle and refilling equipment in the raid on Saturday, an officer said.

"The trio was engaged in illegally storing LPG cylinders and supplying them to local customers without bills or licences," the officer said. They allegedly used metal pipes to transfer gas from multiple filled cylinders into empty ones to manipulate supply and increase margins," the officer said.

"During the search, a large



number of LPG cylinders, weighing machines and gas transfer equipment were found. The accused failed to produce any valid documents for storage or distribution of the cylinders," the officer said.

Among the recovered items were 54 filled and 16 used domestic cylinders, three filled and one used commercial cylinder, an electronic weighing scale, two hanging weighing

KEY POINTS

» Trio was engaged in illegally storing LPG cylinders, supplying them to local customers without bills or licences: Police

» 'They allegedly used metal pipes to transfer gas from multiple filled cylinders into empty ones to manipulate supply, increase margins'

machines and equipment used for refilling gas.

A case has been registered under relevant sections of the Essential Commodities Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at Vasant Kunj North police station. The three have been living in Delhi for over two decades and were allegedly involved in the illegal LPG trade in the Mahipalpur area for the past three years, the police said.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A traffic constable was injured after being struck and dragged by a car during a drunken driving check in west Delhi's Janakpuri on Saturday evening.

Police said the incident occurred around 5:52 pm on March 21 near Bharti College on Lal Sai Marg, where a traffic team comprising Sub-Inspector Gurdeep Singh and Constable Mohan Pal was conducting routine checks. A Santro car was signalled to stop on suspicion, but the driver allegedly attempted to flee.

The vehicle hit Constable Mohan Pal head-on, throwing him onto the bonnet before he fell onto the road after being dragged several metres. Bystanders intervened and helped stop the car.

The injured constable received medical attention, though details of his condition



'Vehicle hit Constable Pal head-on, throwing him onto the bonnet before he fell on the road after being dragged several metres'

were not immediately available.

The driver, identified as Nilesh Kumar, a resident of Bagdola in Dwarka, was apprehended and the vehicle impounded. Police issued a challan under multiple provisions of the Motor Vehicles Act,

including drunken and dangerous driving, disobedience of lawful directions, and related violations.

Officials said further legal action will follow based on the complaint filed by the traffic personnel.

Over 60 nabbed in 4-day drive against criminals in Rohini

44 teams raid 79 locations across dist

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: More than 60 people were arrested during a four-day anti-crime drive in northwest Delhi's Rohini, police said on Sunday, adding that the drive targeted organised and street crime.

The operation, conducted from March 18 to 21, involved 44 teams carrying out raids at 79 locations and checking 165 known offenders as part of intensified policing across the district.

In the crackdown on illegal arms, the police registered 10 cases under the Arms Act and arrested 11 people, allegedly recovering a revolver, a .32 bore pistol, five country-made pistols, 12 live cartridges, four knives and a scooter, they said.

Action against illicit liquor led to 14 cases under the Excise Act, with 14 arrests. The police said that 48 bottles and 13,993 quarters of illegal liquor were seized, along with a car, a tempo and a scooter.

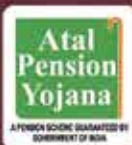


In cases related to gambling, 11 FIRs were registered and 34 people apprehended, with Rs 30,380 recovered as stake money.

Separately, two alleged snatchers were arrested and a stolen mobile phone and a scooter recovered, while an auto-lifter was held with six high-end motorcycles, according to the police.

The police said four of the accused are history sheeters, while several others have prior criminal involvement.

Preventive action was also taken against 768 people under various legal provisions, and 20 were booked for drinking in public places.



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— HOSPITAL INTEGRATION TO BOOST MBBS AND PG SEATS, GIVE NEW PUSH TO RESEARCH: CM REKHA —

Delhi govt to fuse hospitals into AIIMS-style giant

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has unveiled an ambitious plan to integrate major state-run medical institutions to strengthen healthcare delivery and significantly expand medical education capacity. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Sunday.

The proposed integration will bring together Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital (GTB), Delhi State Cancer Institute (DSCI), and Rajiv Gandhi Super Speciality Hospital (RGSSH) into a single autonomous institution, modelled on the lines of All India Institute of Medical Sciences. In parallel, the government is working to develop Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences (IHBAS)



into a second National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences.

Highlighting the vision behind the move, the Chief

Minister said, “The integration of key medical institutions in Delhi will not only strengthen healthcare services but also significantly improve

HEALHUB

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» In parallel, the govern-

ment is working to develop Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences (IHBAS) into a second National Institute of Mental Health and Neurosciences

» The integration of key medical institutions in Delhi will not only strengthen healthcare services but also significantly improve medical education: CM

manpower across institutions have led to underutilisation. “By integrating similar departments and pooling faculty, we can optimise resources and automatically increase PG seats,” she said. Under existing medical norms, an associate professor can guide two PG students, while a professor can supervise three. With the consolidation of faculty from the three hospitals, the number of PG seats is expected to rise significantly without proportionate new hiring. Officials indicated that key departments such as radiology, pathology, and anaesthesia are likely to witness a major jump in seat availability. Radiology seats, currently limited, could increase to around 22, while pathology may see nearly 26 seats and anaesthesia up to 48.

The expansion will also be supported by filling vacant faculty positions across institutions.

The integration will further enable the introduction of PG courses in specialised areas that currently lack such programmes. At DSCI, new seats are expected in fields such as radiation oncology, nuclear medicine, cancer research, and intensive care. Similarly, RGSSH is likely to introduce super-speciality PG seats in cardiology and cardiac surgery. Emphasising the long-term impact, Gupta said, “A key objective of this project is to significantly increase PG seats so that more doctors can receive specialist training and the quality of healthcare can be enhanced.”

The Chief Minister also outlined plans to expand MBBS

seats in the future by increasing bed capacity, patient load, and faculty strength. Supporting infrastructure such as hostels, modern laboratories, and lecture theatres will be developed to ensure a better academic environment. Reiterating the broader vision, Gupta said, “Delhi will be developed as a national hub for medical education and research.” She added that the initiative aims to “optimize the use of faculty, infrastructure, and advanced medical equipment, offering students better training and enhanced research opportunities.” The government believes that this integrated model will not only improve patient care but also position Delhi as a frontrunner in advanced healthcare, medical education, and research.

City Briefs

MOTHER ARRESTED FOR KILLING TWO DAUGHTERS IN MALVIYA NAGAR

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested a 54-year-old woman, who reportedly attempted suicide after the alleged murder of her two daughters at their home in Malviya Nagar, officials said on Sunday. The case pertains to March 6, when the bodies of the two sisters, aged 34 and 28, were found in separate rooms of their ground-floor residence in F-Block, Malviya Nagar, while their mother was discovered unconscious in another room, they said. The police arrested the accused mother, who reportedly consumed a poisonous substance, on Friday after her medical and psychiatric evaluation, they said. Police had initially suspected a murder-suicide attempt and registered a case of murder while waiting to record the woman's statement to establish the sequence of events. Investigators said the elder daughter, who was mentally challenged, was found with a pillow on her face, while the younger one, a law student, had a ligature around her neck, police said. The mother was suspected of having consumed a poisonous substance, they added. According to the police, the woman was allegedly distressed due to a strained relationship with her husband and financial dependence on others, which may have led to the crime. Further investigation into the case is underway, officials added.

MAN POSING AS PROPERTY DEALER ARRESTED FOR CHEATING IN DELHI

NEW DELHI: A man who allegedly posed as a property dealer, gained the trust of buyers and sellers, collected advance payments and then absconded has been arrested by Delhi Police, officials said on Sunday. The accused, Rahul Paswan, a resident of Laxmi Nagar in Delhi and originally from Bihar's Lakhisarai district, was held on Saturday from the parking area near Kashmiri Gate while he was attempting to leave the city, they said. He had been declared a proclaimed offender on February 3, 2023, in connection with a cheating case registered at the Laxmi Nagar police station in April 2022 under relevant sections of the IPC, they said. According to the police, Paswan is involved in multiple cheating cases and has been on the run for nearly a year, during which he stayed in Faridabad, Haryana, to evade arrest. “Acting on credible information, the team laid a trap and apprehended the accused,” a senior police officer said. Paswan's modus operandi involved projecting himself as a genuine property dealer. He would show flats or properties to prospective clients, gain their confidence and collect initial payments before disappearing without completing the deal, the police said. He is wanted in at least three FIRs registered at Laxmi Nagar police station, including cases filed in 2022 and 2024, all pertaining to cheating and fraud, they said. Several complaints have also been reported against him in Gurugram and Faridabad, the officials added. A graduate and fluent in English, Paswan had earlier worked as a property dealer in Laxmi Nagar before shifting base to Gurugram and later Faridabad after allegedly cheating several people, the police added.

MAN HELD FOR POSING AS BUYER, FLEEING WITH BIKES DURING TEST DRIVES

NEW DELHI: A 29-year-old man has been arrested for allegedly posing as a prospective buyer and fleeing with motorcycles that he took on the pretext of a test drive, police said on Sunday. The accused, identified as Punit Satija, a resident of Rewari in Haryana, was held following a probe into a recent motorcycle theft from a showroom, he said. “The case was registered on March 19 after a complaint by a Royal Enfield showroom employee, who alleged that a customer had taken a bike for a test drive and did not return,” Deputy Commissioner of Police (Rohini) Shashank Jaiswal said in a statement. Police traced the accused to the Bhalaswa Dairy area, where he was arrested on March 21 and found in possession of a stolen motorcycle, they said. During interrogation, Satija confessed to stealing multiple motorcycles across Delhi-NCR using a similar modus operandi. At his instance, six stolen high-end motorcycles were recovered, the DCP said. With his arrest, at least nine cases of motorcycle theft across Delhi and neighbouring areas have been worked out, police said, adding that further investigation is underway.

Delhi Budget Session begins today

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Assembly's Budget Session will commence with a 'kheer' ceremony on Monday, with the Opposition AAP threatening to boycott the session.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta will attend the 'kheer' ceremony and is also likely to table Delhi's Economic Survey report in the House, officials said.

Earlier in the day, Leader of Opposition Atishi said that AAP MLAs will boycott the session if the Speaker does not revoke the suspension of four MLAs of the party.

The four AAP MLAs — chief whip Sanjeev Jha, Jarnail Singh, Kuldeep Kumar and Somdutt — were suspended in the Assembly session held in January for “disrupting” proceedings of the House. Their suspension continues as the previous sitting of the House was not prorogued.

Officials said that the four AAP MLAs were suspended for the whole session and their suspension will be lifted if the Budget Session is properly prorogued.

The leader of opposition

HIGHLIGHTS

» Chief Minister Rekha Gupta will attend the 'kheer' ceremony and is also likely to table Delhi's Economic Survey report in the House

» Leader of Opposition Atishi said that AAP MLAs will boycott the session if the Speaker does not revoke the suspension of four MLAs of the party

in a letter written to Speaker Vijender Gupta raised concern over the treatment meted to the AAP MLAs, saying it is not in



line with democratic values or established legislative procedures. She expressed hope that the Speaker would take cognisance of these concerns and ensure that the Assembly functions in accordance with established legislative traditions.

She has also demanded that the suspension of the four AAP MLAs be revoked.

The chief minister, who also holds the finance portfolio, will table her second annual budget on March 24. She presented her maiden budget for Delhi worth Rs one lakh crore last year.

The first day of the session will also witness tabling of various reports of the Controller and Auditor General (CAG) related to audit of Delhi's finances, revenue, children in need of care, Delhi Jal Board, among others.

The reports of the Public Accounts Committee and Privileges Committee will also be tabled in the House. The members will also raise issues of their constituencies under Rule 280, said the List of Business of the House.

Water supply hit in NDMC areas after pipeline burst at Chandrawal plant

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council on Sunday issued an advisory informing residents of a disruption in water supply across several parts of the Capital following a pipeline burst at the Chandrawal Water Treatment Plant.

According to information received from the Delhi Jal Board (DJB), the main water pipeline at the plant has suffered damage, and repair work is expected to take approximately 3 days

» As a result, water supply sourced from the Chandr-

KEY POINTS

» According to information received from the DJB, the main water pipeline at the plant has suffered damage, and repair work is expected to take approximately 3 days

» As a result, water supply sourced from the Chandr-

awal plant will remain affected during this period. The civic body has urged residents to use water judiciously and cooperate during the repair period

» NDMC has arranged water tanker services, with control room numbers and officials designated for assistance

Road, DIZ Area, Shivaji Stadium vicinity, Valmiki Basti, Palika Kendra, Connaught Place, and several government residential colonies and institutional zones.

Areas such as Parliament House, Delhi Police Headquarters, RML Hospital, Sarojini Nagar, South Avenue, and Diplomatic Enclave are also expected to experience reduced or disrupted supply, particularly during evening hours.

The civic body has urged residents to use water judiciously and cooperate during the repair period. To mitigate inconvenience, NDMC has arranged water tanker services, with control room numbers and officials designated for assistance.

Authorities assured that efforts are underway to restore normal supply at the earliest while minimising inconvenience to the public.

‘FOCUS REMAINS ON TRANSFORMING CITY'S CHALLENGES INTO OPPORTUNITIES...’

L-G offers prayers, ‘seva’ at Bangla Sahib

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sandhu visited Gurdwara Bangla Sahib to mark the Jyoti-Jot Diwas of the second Sikh Guru, Guru Angad Dev, where he offered prayers and participated in voluntary 'Jod Seva'.

Despite being invited to take part in 'Langar Seva', which involves serving food and cleaning utensils, the Lieutenant Governor chose 'Jod Seva', the act of cleaning and arranging footwear of devotees. The practice is widely regarded as a symbol of humility and selfless service in Sikh tradition.

Sources close to Sandhu said that his association with 'Jod Seva' dates back to his student days. While studying at St. Stephen's College, he would regularly visit Gurdwara Sis Ganj Sahib and perform the



same service. He continued the practice during his early career after joining the Indian Foreign Service, including visits to Bangla Sahib while residing in central Delhi.

During his tenure at the Ministry of External Affairs in South Block, Sandhu is also

known to have undertaken 'Jod Seva' at Gurdwara Rakab Ganj Sahib.

Observers familiar with Sikh customs note that various forms of 'Seva', including 'Kar Seva' and 'Langar Seva', are commonly performed to cultivate humility and community spirit. 'Jod Seva', however, is often seen as the most modest form of service and is less frequently chosen voluntarily.

Speaking on the occasion, Sandhu said he visited the gurdwara “to seek blessings of Guru Angad Dev Ji for the responsibilities ahead in Delhi.” He added that his focus remains on transforming the city's challenges into opportunities for growth and development.

The visit coincided with religious observances at Bangla Sahib, where devotees gathered in large numbers to pay homage to the revered Sikh Guru.

Illegal liquor seized in Chandni Chowk during surprise inspection

NEW DELHI: Illegal liquor was seized in Delhi's Chandni Chowk area during a surprise inspection led by MCD Standing Committee Chairperson Satya Sharma on Sunday, officials said.

In a statement and video shared by her official handle on X, Sharma alleged lapses on the part of enforcement agencies.

“During a surprise inspection, illegal liquor was seized in the Chandni Chowk area. Such activities are flourishing due to the collusion of Delhi Police and the negligence of MCD,” she said. Calling the issue serious, Sharma said directions have been issued for an immediate inquiry and strict action against those responsible. “This is a very serious issue that requires strict action,” she added.

FIT RIDE

Participants take part in the 'Fit India Sundays on Cycle' event at Major Dhyani Chand National Stadium, in New Delhi, on Sunday

‘Bihar Diwas’: CM launches celebrations; PM extends greetings

MPOST BUREAU

PATNA: Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on Sunday inaugurated the three-day Bihar Diwas celebrations in the state capital, even as Prime Minister Narendra Modi extended his greetings to the people of Bihar and lauded the state's progress under Kumar's leadership.

Bihar, which was carved out of the Bengal Presidency on March 22, 1912, is marking its foundation day with a series of cultural and public events across the state. The main programme in Patna began at the historic Gandhi Maidan, where Kumar lit a ceremonial lamp and released balloons to formally open the celebrations.

The state government has organised a range of programmes over three days, including folk music performances, traditional dances and exhibitions highlighting Bihar's rich cultural heritage, history and art. Deputy Chief Ministers Samrat Choudhary and Vijay Kumar Sinha were among those present at the inauguration ceremony.

Meanwhile, PM Modi wrote a detailed letter to Kumar, congratulating him and the people of the state on Bihar Diwas. The Chief Minister shared the Prime Minister's letter on social media.

In his message, the PM praised Kumar's "personal commitment towards the welfare of all sections of society" and said that Bihar had witnessed "a huge transformation" under his leadership. He also expressed pride that the Centre had been able to contribute to the state's development.

The Prime Minister highlighted Bihar's glorious past, referring to the teachings of Gautam Buddha, the governance of Chandragupta Maurya guided by Chanakya, and the role of the Champaran Satyagraha led by Mahatma Gandhi. He also mentioned prominent figures such as Rajendra Prasad, Jagjivan Ram and Jayaprakash Narayan.

Modi further noted that the conferment of the Bharat Ratna on Karpoori Thakur by the NDA government had been widely appreciated.

Indo-Tibet trade to resume via Shipki La pass from June

MPOST BUREAU

SHIMLA: The stage is set for the resumption of Indo-Tibet trade, suspended in 2020 due to Covid pandemic, through the Shipki La pass in Kinnaur on the Himachal Pradesh border from June this year, Tribal Development and Revenue Minister Jagat Singh Negi said here on Sunday. Citing security concerns and other factors, he said many restrictions were in place earlier, preventing tourists and traders from accessing these areas. With the easing of curbs, the resumption of trade is expected to boost commerce and generate employment in Kinnaur and nearby regions, he added.

Negi said that traditional trade remained in limbo for several years, and local traders' unions and Associations had been demanding its revival. He expressed hope that trading activities would resume in June, once weather conditions



improve. Negi also urged the Union government to develop the Shipki La pass road to facilitate the Kailash-Mansarovar Yatra, noting that building just 3 to 4 Km of connectivity would facilitate a smoother and shorter journey.

Kailash-Mansarovar is of great importance to followers of Hindu, Bodh and Jain dharma and opening this route would also boost adventure tourism and tourist inflow, he said, adding that the Members of Parlia-

ment from Himachal should also raise this demand.

The Indo-Tibetan trade has a long history. In 1697, a formal treaty was signed between Tibet (Ganden Phodrang) and Raja Kehari Singh of Bushahar, which guaranteed safe passage, cementing a long-term trade partnership, and trading was done on a barter (exchange) basis through the old Hindustan-Tibet road.

Tibetan traders imported quality wool, sheep, salt, yak tails, and raw silk, while Indian

Trade was largely halted in 1962 due to the Sino-Indian War, but limited, regulated trade resumed in 1994 after several decades, which was again discontinued during Covid in 2020

traders exported items like copperware, rice, textiles, tea and agricultural tools and trade was based on 'gamgya' (a traditional folk oath of mutual trust) rather than written contracts.

The trade was largely halted in 1962 due to the Sino-Indian War, but limited, regulated trade resumed in 1994 after several decades, which was again discontinued during Covid in 2020.

Death toll rises to 16 in Andhra milk adulteration case

Rajamahendravaram (Andhra Pradesh): The death toll in the suspected milk adulteration case in East Godavari district has risen to 16, while three persons are currently undergoing treatment at hospitals in Rajamahendravaram, officials said on Sunday.

The incident dates back to mid-February when adulterated milk supplied in parts of Lalacheruvu allegedly caused severe health complications among consumers, including vomiting, abdominal pain, anuria and acute renal dysfunction, leading to multiple hospitalisations.

The case came to light on February 22 after a cluster of patients with acute kidney failure symptoms was reported from Chowdeswaranagar and Swaroopanagar areas, prompting health authorities to launch an epidemiological investigation.

Laboratory findings show that the 16 victims died of multi-organ failure triggered by acute renal failure after consuming milk contaminated with the toxic substance eth-

ylene glycol, according to an official press release issued on Sunday.

"Preliminary findings indicate that the victims suffered acute renal failure with elevated blood urea and serum creatinine levels, suggesting toxic exposure likely linked to contaminated milk consumption," the release said.

Milk supplied to over 100 families from a dairy unit in Narasapuram village under Korukonda mandal was identified as the suspected source, following which supply from the unit was immediately stopped, it said.

Between February 16 and March 21, a total of 20 persons were admitted to various hospitals, of whom 16 succumbed, while three remain under treatment, and one was discharged after recovery.

Authorities said the patients included elderly persons and children, with several requiring dialysis and ventilator support, while emergency medical camps and surveillance measures were deployed in affected localities.

AGENCIES

Opposition MPs and activists seek rollback of transgender bill

NEW DELHI: Opposition MPs and transgender rights activists on Sunday called for the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026, to be withdrawn, saying the proposed changes could dilute their rights.

The call to rollback the Bill was made at a Jan Sunwai (public discussion) held at the Press Club of India here, where participants raised concerns over its potential impact on transgender people.

Social Justice and Empowerment Minister Virendra Kumar introduced the Bill in Lok Sabha on March 13.

The Bill seeks to give a precise definition of the term "transgender" and provide graded punishments that reflect the gravity

of the harm inflicted upon such persons.

It also underlines that a transgender person "shall not include, nor shall ever have been so included, persons with different sexual orientations and self-perceived sexual identities".

The proposed amendment to the existing Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, has triggered criticism from members of the community who say it departs from principles laid down by the Supreme Court in the landmark judgement of National Legal Services Authority vs Union of India.

NCP spokesperson Anish Gawande, speaking to PTI, said there is a clear demand to withdraw the Bill. "If the government is not willing to withdraw it,

then it should be referred to the Standing Committee on Social Justice and Empowerment for reconsideration," he said.

Congress leader Sandeep Dikshit said the Bill should be sent to a parliamentary standing committee and emphasised that individuals must be respected as they are, calling it the duty of the state and government.

Dikshit also emphasised the need to recognise individuals first as human beings. "In our society, identity is often attacked repeatedly. The state and institutions must first treat every person as a human being, and then as a citizen," he said.

"The duty of the state and Parliament is to respect individuals as they are -- their identity, their choices and their sense of

self -- and stand by them with dignity," he added.

Manoj Jha, a Rajya Sabha MP from the Rashtriya Janata Dal, said: "This is a case of constitutional morality versus majoritarianism. The government cannot rely only on numbers. It must be guided by constitutional values." "There is a need for a collective strategy inside Parliament, reaching across party lines to build consensus and challenge such measures," Jha said.

"We need to come together, both inside and outside Parliament, and build a coordinated strategy to oppose such measures," he added.

CPI(M) leader John Brittas raised concerns over the proposed amendments, saying they go against the principle of self-

identification. "It restricts access to legal identity and raises serious questions about self-determination," he said.

"At a time when legislation should be progressive, we are witnessing a regressive shift that could push the community backwards," Brittas added.

He questioned the authority to determine identity. "Who is to decide a person's identity? The state cannot impose identity on individuals," he said.

Referring to global practices, Brittas said, "Several countries such as Denmark, Malta and Ireland have moved towards self-identification. India should be moving forward, not backwards."

Highlighting ground realities, he added, "Even today, many people are hesitant to openly

identify themselves. Adding more layers of scrutiny will only make it more difficult."

"This is the time to protect diversity and uphold dignity. We must stand together to ensure that the rights of the community are not diluted," Brittas said.

Congress Rajya Sabha MP Renuka Chowdhury said the community would continue to resist the proposed changes and fight for their rights.

"Even if the Bill is passed in Parliament, the fight will not end. We will continue to raise our voice and stand with the community," she said.

"We are not going to be afraid. This is not an easy journey, but we have to fight it collectively," Chowdhury added.

She also raised concerns

about the implementation of the law at the grassroots level, questioning how district magistrates in smaller towns would be sensitised to deal with transgender persons seeking official recognition.

Reiterating her support, she said that while the road ahead may be challenging, there remains hope, and she stands firmly with the community.

Grace Banu, a transgender rights activist, highlighted the long history of struggle for recognition and dignity, saying the proposed changes undermine years of progress.

"For decades, we have been fighting to define our own identity. After years of struggle, self-identification was recognised, and now it is being taken away,"

she said. Recalling past experiences, she alleged instances of invasive verification processes. "We have faced humiliating examinations and questioning about our bodies. Such practices violate basic human rights and dignity," Banu said.

She said the community continues to face discrimination and violence. "Even today, many in our community face abuse within families, social exclusion and are pushed into marginalised livelihoods," she said.

"We have the right to live with dignity like any other citizen. This Bill goes against that principle," Banu added. She called for unity and wider support on the issue. "Our fight will continue -- whether we win or not, we will not stop," she said.

AGENCIES

From Page 1 PM chairs

Describing the situation as fluid with global consequences, Modi said the conflict is affecting countries worldwide in varying degrees. "All efforts must be made to safeguard citizens from its impact," he said, calling for close coordination among all arms of government to ensure minimal inconvenience.

The CCS, the country's top decision-making body on strategic and security matters, reviewed in detail the availability of critical supplies. These included food grains, fertilisers, fuel, electricity and other essentials that directly affect households and businesses. The meeting also examined the broader macroeconomic outlook and potential policy responses.

Officials said the discussions covered a wide range of sectors, including agriculture, fertilisers, petroleum, power, shipping, trade, finance, supply chains, MSMEs and exports. The expected short, medium and long-term impact of the conflict on the global economy, and consequently on India, was assessed alongside possible countermeasures.

In a post on X after the meeting, Modi said there were extensive deliberations on steps such as ensuring continued fertiliser availability for farmers, diversifying import sources and identifying new export markets. "We are committed to safeguarding our citizens from the impact of the conflict," he said.

The requirement of fertilisers for the upcoming kharif season was reviewed, with officials noting that stockpiling measures taken in recent years would help maintain adequate supply. The government also explored alternative sourcing options to secure future availability and maintain food security.

On the energy front, it was assessed that sufficient coal stocks at power plants would prevent electricity shortages. The situation relating to crude oil, natural gas and other petroleum products was also reviewed in light of the disruptions triggered by the conflict.

Sources said the meeting

placed strong focus on maintaining uninterrupted supply chains, stable logistics and efficient distribution systems across the country. Measures were also discussed to diversify import sources for key industrial sectors such as chemicals, pharmaceuticals and petrochemicals, which are sensitive to global supply disruptions.

At the same time, the government is planning to expand export outreach to new destinations to support Indian businesses affected by shifting trade patterns. Several proposals put forward by different ministries will be finalised and implemented after consultations with stakeholders in the coming days.

Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan made a detailed presentation on the global situation and the steps already taken by various ministries. Future plans were also outlined as part of a coordinated response strategy.

The prime minister instructed officials to work closely with state governments to prevent hoarding and black marketing of essential commodities, ensuring that supplies remain accessible and affordable for consumers.

The meeting was attended by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Home Minister Amit Shah, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, who are members of the CCS. Several other senior ministers were invited due to the cross-sectoral nature of the crisis, including Shivraj Singh Chouhan, J P Nadda, Piyush Goyal, Ashwini Vaishnaw, Sarbananda Sonowal, Manohar Lal Khattar, Pralhad Joshi, Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu and Hardeep Singh Puri.

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval and senior officials from the Prime Minister's Office were also present.

The conflict in West Asia began on February 28, when the United States and Israel carried out strikes on Iran. Iran responded with attacks targeting Israel and several Gulf countries hosting US military bases, escalating tensions across the region.

A key concern for India and other energy-importing nations has been the situation in the Strait of Hormuz, controlled by Iran. The route accounts for about 20 per cent of global energy shipments. Since the outbreak of hostilities, Iran has allowed only

limited shipping through the passage, leading to significant disruptions in global energy supply.

The prime minister had earlier, on March 12, described the conflict as having triggered a worldwide energy crisis, calling it a test that requires calm, patience and awareness. He had also said that efforts were underway to address disruptions in international supply chains.

In recent weeks, Modi has spoken with leaders from several countries, including Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, Jordan, France, Malaysia, Israel and Iran, as part of diplomatic outreach linked to the crisis.

Officials said the government would continue to monitor the situation closely and adjust its response as the conflict evolves, with the priority remaining the protection of citizens and economic stability.

Govt directs

Safety Organisation has directed its offices to clear City Gas Distribution applications within 10 days. The step is intended to expand access to piped natural gas across urban areas.

Authorities have also advised commercial LPG users in major cities to transition to PNG, part of a broader effort to reduce reliance on liquefied petroleum gas amid ongoing geopolitical pressures affecting global supply chains.

Officials said domestic LPG availability remains steady, with no reports of supply disruptions at distributorships and normal delivery patterns nationwide. Most deliveries are now being carried out using the Delivery Authentication Code system, while panic-driven bookings have declined.

On the commercial front, allocations have been raised in phases. After restoring 20 per cent supply earlier, the government announced an additional 10 per cent increase on March 18 linked to PNG expansion reforms. A further 20 per cent hike approved on March 21 has taken total commercial LPG supply to 50 per cent.

The latest allocation prioritises restaurants, dhabs, hotels, industrial canteens, food processing

units, dairy operations, community kitchens and subsidised food outlets run by local authorities. Provision has also been made for 5 kg cylinders to support migrant workers.

Revised allocation guidelines have been implemented in about 20 states and Union Territories, while public sector oil marketing companies continue supplying the remaining regions. Over the past eight days, commercial consumers have lifted around 15,440 tonnes of LPG.

Educational institutions and hospitals remain priority recipients, accounting for nearly half of total commercial LPG allocations, as the government maintains that domestic supply is under control despite global uncertainties.

Trump attacks power plants

power plants if Tehran fails to fully open the Strait of Hormuz, setting a 48-hour deadline on Saturday. Iran's parliament speaker said if the US follows through on its threat, Tehran will retaliate against American and Israeli energy and wider infrastructure in the region.

The developments signalled the Iran war, which the US and Israel launched on February 28, was moving in a dangerous new direction, despite Trump's mention last week he was considering "winding down" operations. It has killed hundreds of people, rattled the global economy and sent oil prices surging.

Hezbollah claimed responsibility for an airstrike Sunday that killed a man in northern Israel while Gulf Arab states -- including Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates -- said they were intercepting fresh barrages of new Iranian strikes.

Iran has practically closed the Strait of Hormuz, a choke-point connecting the Persian Gulf to the rest of the world through which roughly one-fifth of global supply passes. Attacks on ships and threats of further strikes have stopped nearly all tankers from navigating the strait, compelling some of the largest oil producers to make cuts because their crude has nowhere to go.

The blockade is a liability for both the US and its allies in Europe and Asia, who rely heavily on the Persian Gulf supply to meet energy demand and power factories, vehicles and homes.

The US lifted some sanctions on Iranian oil at sea to relieve pressure on energy prices.

Iran said its strikes in the Negev Desert were in retaliation to an earlier attack on Iran's main nuclear enrichment site in Natanz, according to state-run media.

"If the Israeli regime is unable to intercept missiles in the heavily protected Dimona area, it is, operationally, a sign of entering a new phase of the battle," Qalibaf said.

Dimona is about 20 kilometres west of the nuclear research centre, and Arad about 35 kilometres to the north.

Israel is widely believed to possess nuclear weapons, though it doesn't confirm or deny their existence. The UN nuclear watchdog said on X it had not received reports of damage to the Israeli centre or abnormal radiation levels.

Israel denied responsibility for hitting Natanz on Saturday while the Iranian judiciary's official news agency, Mizan, said there was no leakage. The Pentagon declined to comment on the strike at Natanz, which was also hit in the first week of the ongoing war and in the 12-day war last June.

The UN watchdog -- the International Atomic Energy Agency -- has said the bulk of Iran's estimated 441 kilograms of enriched uranium is elsewhere, beneath the rubble at its Isfahan facility.

Iran's death toll in the war surpassed 1,500 on Saturday, state media reported, citing the ministry. In Israel, 15 people have been killed by Iranian strikes. More than a dozen civilians in the occupied West Bank and Gulf Arab states have been killed in strikes.

The war has also seen non-combat-related accidents, including a US refuelling plane crash in Iraq that killed six US service members and a Qatari military helicopter crash on Saturday blamed on a technical malfunction. All seven aboard were killed, Qatari authorities said Sunday.

UNESCO

been swift. Only 24 per cent of countries had such restrictions in mid-2023. This increased to 40 per cent by early 2025 and climbed further by nearly 20 percentage points by March 2026, a senior member of the GEM team told PTI.

"The growth reflects mounting concerns about declining attention in classrooms, cyberbullying, and the broader influence of digital environments on children," the official said, adding that policies vary widely across regions.

Several countries have adopted national bans since late 2025, including Bolivia, Costa Rica, Croatia, Georgia, the Maldives and Malta. In many cases, restrictions apply during school hours or inside classrooms, with exceptions for educational use or for students with specific needs.

At the same time, some governments are opting for flexible frameworks rather than outright bans. Countries such as Comoros, Colombia, Estonia, Lithuania, Iceland, Peru, Indonesia, Serbia, Poland and the Philippines require schools to set their own policies to limit phone use, reflecting a shift toward school-level decision-making.

Debate continues in countries like France, which was among the earliest to introduce restrictions on mobile phones in primary and lower secondary schools. Lawmakers there are now considering additional rules to regulate smartphone use more precisely.

In decentralised systems, policy changes are often emerging at local levels. In the United States, there is no nationwide ban, but 39 states have implemented restrictions or required school districts to adopt policies. Many others are considering similar measures, indicating that reforms often begin regionally before expanding.

The report also highlights the impact of social media on students' well-being, particularly among girls. It found that girls are twice as likely as boys to experience eating disorders linked to online content. Internal research by Facebook showed that 32 per cent of teenage girls felt worse about their bodies after using Instagram.

Further, TikTok's algorithm was found to push body image-

related content to teenagers every 39 seconds and material linked to eating disorders every eight minutes. Increased social media exposure at age 10 has been associated with worsening socioemotional outcomes later, a pattern not observed among boys.

In response, countries including Australia, France, Portugal and Spain are exploring or implementing restrictions on children's social media use, with similar discussions underway in Denmark, the Czech Republic and Indonesia.

AGENCIES

Russian oil

Port around 11:30 am after reversing course in mid-March during its journey to China's Rizhao port. It had been loaded at a Baltic Sea terminal in late January. The diversion comes after the United States granted India a 30-day temporary waiver to purchase sanctioned Russian oil, a move aimed at easing global supply pressures following escalating tensions involving Iran. US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said the waiver was intended to reduce strain on energy markets, while the White House noted India had previously halted such purchases and was being supported as a key partner.

Ship-tracking firm Vortexa has indicated that at least seven tankers originally headed for China are now being redirected to India. Another vessel, the Suezmax Zouzou N, is expected to arrive at Gujarat's Sikka port on March 25 after altering its route earlier this month.

The rerouting comes as India seeks to secure energy supplies, with around 40 to 50 per cent of its crude imports, along with nearly half of its LNG and most LPG shipments, typically passing through the Strait of Hormuz.

Recent arrivals include the tanker Jag Laadki, which delivered 80,886 metric tonnes of Murban crude from the UAE to Mundra, and the Shenlong Suezmax, which transited the Hormuz route from Saudi Arabia. Meanwhile, LPG carrier Pyxis Pioneer from Texas docked at New Mangaluru Port on Sunday, as authorities began safety checks and unloading procedures to address domestic fuel demand.



उत्तराखण्ड शासन

देवभूमि उत्तराखण्ड
Uttarakhand Government

जन-जन की सरकार 4 साल बेमिसाल उत्तरोत्तर विकास पथ पर अग्रसर उत्तराखण्ड



“ 21वीं सदी के विकसित भारत के निर्माण के दो प्रमुख स्तंभ हैं। पहला, अपनी विरासत पर गर्व और दूसरा, विकास के लिए हर संभव प्रयास। आज उत्तराखण्ड इन दोनों ही स्तंभों को लगातार मजबूत कर रहा है। ये दशक उत्तराखण्ड का दशक है। ”

नरेन्द्र मोदी, प्रधानमंत्री



“ प्रधानमंत्री श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी जी के दूरदर्शी मार्गदर्शन में उत्तराखण्ड सर्वांगीण विकास की नई मिसाल बन रहा है। स्थानीय उत्पाद, बेहतर कनेक्टिविटी, उद्योग एवं निवेश तथा हर मौसम पर्यटन सहित देवभूमि अपनी अलौकिक विरासत को संजोते हुए विकास के नए आयाम छू रही है। ”

पुष्कर सिंह धामी, मुख्यमंत्री, उत्तराखण्ड

विकसित भारत सशक्त उत्तराखण्ड



विरासत भी, विकास भी



इंफ्रास्ट्रक्चर एवं कनेक्टिविटी

- केदारनाथ-हेमकुंड साहिब रोपवे परियोजना
- दिल्ली-देहरादून एलिक्ट्रिक रोड निर्माण
- ऋषिकेश-कर्णप्रयाग रेल लाइन प्रगति पर
- टनकपुर-बागेश्वर रेल सर्वे स्वीकृत
- सौगं व जमरानी बांध परियोजना
- पर्वतीय जिलों में हेली सेवा विस्तार

- ₹3.56 लाख करोड़ निवेश समझौते
- ₹1 लाख करोड़+ ग्राउंडिंग
- अर्थव्यवस्था 26 गुना वृद्धि
- ₹1.11 लाख करोड़+ वार्षिक बजट
- सुरपिया में स्मार्ट इंडस्ट्रियल टाउनशिप
- हाउस ऑफ हिमालयाज ब्रांड

अर्थव्यवस्था, निवेश एवं उद्योग



- 1 गीगावाट+ सौर ऊर्जा क्षमता
- 42,000+ सोलर रूफटॉप
- वाइब्रेंट विलेज प्रोग्राम (सीमांत गांव विकास)
- महक क्रांति व मिलेट्स मिशन

हरित ऊर्जा एवं ग्रामीण विकास



संस्कृति एवं विरासत का संरक्षण

- केदारनाथ-बदरीनाथ मास्टर प्लान
- मानसखण्ड मंदिर माला मिशन
- शीतकालीन यात्रा का शुभारंभ
- संस्कृत ग्राम पहल
- गीता अध्ययन पाठ्यक्रम में शामिल
- दून विश्वविद्यालय में हिंदू अध्ययन केंद्र
- स्मिरिचुअल इकोनॉमिक ज़ोन (गढ़वाल-कुमाऊं)



सुशासन

- 'जन-जन की सरकार, जन-जन के द्वार' अभियान
- 30,000+ युवाओं को सरकारी नौकरी
- 950+ सेवाएं ऑनलाइन (अपुणि सरकार पोर्टल)
- 12,000 एकड़ अतिक्रमण मुक्त
- पेंशन योजनाओं में वृद्धि एवं मासिक भुगतान

- समान नागरिक संहिता
- सशक्त भू-कानून
- सख्त धर्मांतरण विरोधी कानून
- नकल विरोधी कानून
- अग्निवीरों को 10% क्षैतिज आरक्षण

बड़े निर्णय



संकल्प से शिखर तक



नेशनल लेवल रैंकिंग व प्रोत्साहन

- निर्यात तैयारी सूचकांक में प्रथम (छोटे राज्य)
- एसडीजी इंडेक्स में शीर्ष स्थान
- स्टार्टअप रैंकिंग में 'लीडर'
- खनन सुधारों में देश में दूसरा स्थान
- शहरी सुधारों हेतु ₹264.5 करोड़ प्रोत्साहन



30 से अधिक नीतियां

- औद्योगिक नीति, पर्यटन एवं योग नीति
- नई फिल्म नीति (50% तक सब्सिडी)
- मिलेट्स नीति, कीवी नीति (70% अनुदान)
- ड्रेगन फ्रूट प्रोत्साहन योजना
- महक क्रांति 2026-36
- महिला स्वरोजगार एवं लखपति दीदी योजना आदि

नीतिगत सुधार



प्रधानमंत्री जी के नौ आग्रह

स्थानीय लोगों से: बोली-भाषा का संरक्षण, एक पेड़ मां के नाम, स्वच्छ जल, गांव से जुड़ाव, तिबारी वाले घरों को संवारें
पर्यटकों से: प्लास्टिक के इस्तेमाल से बचें, वोकल फॉर लोकल, यातायात के नियम अपनाएं, तीर्थों की मर्यादा का पालन करें।

सूचना एवं लोक सम्पर्क विभाग, उत्तराखण्ड द्वारा जनहित में जारी

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SUO MOTU MATTER CONCERNING ‘INHUMAN’ CONDITIONS IN JAILS

Furnish updated data on prisons, occupancy, SC tells states and UTs

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has directed all the states and Union territories to furnish updated details relating to jails, including the sanctioned capacity of each prison and steps taken to check overcrowding, by May 18.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta also asked the states and UTs to provide details about the number of women's prisons within their jurisdictions and the facilities available in them, including the measures taken to ensure education and overall welfare of children living with the female inmates.

The bench noted that senior advocate Gaurav Agrawal, who is assisting the top court as an amicus curiae in a suo motu matter concerning inhuman conditions in jails, has drawn its attention to the fact that the statistics placed on record by

HIGHLIGHTS

» The bench directed the states and UTs to furnish complete particulars indicating the sanctioned capacity of each prison and the total number of prisoners lodged as on March 1, 2026

» The apex court said the states and UTs would file comprehensive affidavits, duly sworn by the home secretary, providing the requisite details by May 18

» It said the top court registry would forward copies of the affidavits received from the states and UTs to the amicus,



who would prepare a comprehensive note detailing the statistics and information provided by them

the states and UTs pertain to 2023.

The bench said that, having regard to the nature of issues involved and the necessity of an informed adjudicatory exercise, the availability of updated contemporaneous data was indispensable for the effective consideration of the proceedings.

“Accordingly, we deem it appropriate to direct all the states and Union territories to place on record updated and comprehensive statistics relating to all prisons situated within their respective jurisdictions,” the bench said in its order passed on March 17.

It said the data shall include jail-wise capacity of

each prison, total number of prisoners, percentage of overcrowding in each jail, steps proposed to address overcrowding, details of women's jails, facilities provided to women prisoners and children accompanying them (including educational and medical facilities), sanctioned strength of prison staff, exist-

ing vacancies, steps taken to fill them, along with all ancillary aspects relating to prison administration.

The bench directed the states and UTs to furnish complete particulars indicating the sanctioned capacity of each prison and the total number of prisoners lodged as on March 1, 2026, along with jail-wise details reflecting the extent of occupancy.

The apex court said the states and UTs would file comprehensive affidavits, duly sworn by the home secretary, providing the requisite details by May 18.

It said the top court registry would forward copies of the affidavits received from the states and UTs to the amicus, who would prepare a comprehensive note detailing the statistics and information provided by them.

It posted the matter for hearing on May 26.

Parl panel seeks update on Lokpal’s prosecution wing

What is being done to operationalise inquiry, prosecution arms?

MPOST BUREAU

INSIGHT

» The committee desires to be apprised of the present status of appointment of the director and the steps taken to operationalise

the inquiry wing in its full statutory form

» The panel said that the prosecution wing of the Lokpal has been formally constituted through an order dated June 6, 2025

for the prosecution of public servants.

In its latest report, the Department-related Parliamentary Standing Committee on Personnel, Public Grievances, Law and Justice noted that the appointment of the Director of Inquiry and staffing of the inquiry wing in accordance with the approved organogram is still in process.

The committee, therefore, desires to be apprised of the present status of appointment of the director and the steps taken to operationalise the inquiry wing in its full statutory form, while ensuring coordination with existing investigative agencies, it said.

The panel, in its 160th report, said that the prosecution wing of the Lokpal has been formally constituted through an order dated June 6, 2025.

The committee noted that, at present, matters relating to prosecution are being handled through the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), which has its own prosecution mechanism.

“While taking note of the constitution of the Prosecution Wing, the committee desires to be apprised of the present stage of operationalisation of the prosecution wing and the proposed roadmap for making it fully functional in accordance with the statutory framework,” the report said.

Govt making ‘sustained efforts’ to restore Punjab’s pristine glory: CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann on Sunday said the Punjab government is making sustained efforts to restore the state’s “pristine glory” across sectors, asserting that Punjab is once again moving towards vibrancy and holistic development.

Addressing a gathering during the Virasati Mela, the Chief Minister said such cultural fairs, once integral to Punjab’s identity, had declined due to the neglect of previous regimes. “Punjab has fallen many times but has risen again, and today the colours of a ‘Rangla Punjab’ are visible once again,” he said, adding that the government is committed to preserving the state’s rich heritage.

“Punjab is once again moving towards vibrancy and holistic development”

Mann highlighted that traditional performances like Giddha and Bhangra at such events reflect the true spirit of Punjab and help connect younger generations with their roots. He said pro-people initiatives are improving lives, with government jobs being provided on merit and canal water reaching even tail-end villages.

He noted that canal water is now being lifted to the sand dunes of Bathinda and infrastructure is being upgraded across the state. The Chief Minister also spoke

about the Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojna, which provides cashless treatment up to Rs 10 lakh to all 65 lakh families, irrespective of income, including government employees and pensioners.

Emphasising reforms, Mann said Punjab has ensured free healthcare through 881 Aam Aadmi Clinics and that nearly 90 per cent of households are receiving free electricity. He added that uninterrupted daytime power supply to farm tube wells during the paddy season marked a significant achievement.

On tackling drug abuse, he said promoting sports through initiatives like “Khedan Watan Punjab Dian” is key, alongside the “Yudh Nashean Virudh” campaign, which has intensified action against drug networks.

SIDHI COLLECTOR, GUNA SP REMOVED OVER ‘LAPSES’ MP CM Yadav cracks whip after surprise inspection

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: In a stern show of administrative accountability, Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Sunday ordered the removal of the Sidhi Collector and Guna SP, and suspended a district cooperative bank GM over complaints of irregularities and lapses.

The action followed a surprise inspection by the CM in Sidhi district, during which he interacted directly with citizens and public representatives to assess the on-the-ground implementation of government schemes and the administration’s functioning.

Based on complaints and feedback received during the visit, Yadav directed the immediate removal of Sidhi Collector Swarochit Somvanshi. He also ordered



the suspension of PS Dhanwal, General Manager of the Sidhi district cooperative bank. Hours after the Chief Minister’s directions, the state government issued formal orders appointing Vikas Mishra as the new Collector of Sidhi.

In a separate action, Yadav ordered the removal of Guna Superintendent of Police Ankit Soni, stating that his role in a mat-

ter involving alleged irregularities in handling seized cash during a search operation was “not found appropriate”. Subsequently, Hitika Basal has been posted as the new Superintendent of Police (SP) of Guna.

Taking a tough stand on governance, the Chief Minister asserted that administrative laxity, negligence or irregularities would not be tolerated at any level. He

emphasised that accountability is inherent to an officer’s posting and must be upheld at all times. “Officers must discharge their duties with full responsibility. Accountability comes with the very appointment,” he said, adding that strict action against erring officials would continue.

Yadav reiterated that if officers fail to resolve public grievances while being in the field, they forfeit their right to hold such postings.

During the inspection, the Chief Minister expressed concern over the slow progress of Sidhi’s under-construction collectorate, directing officials to expedite work without compromising quality, and stressed that welfare benefits must reach all eligible citizens on time, urging officials to act with accountability and warning of strict action for negligence.

CM: Haryana playing ‘pivotal role’ in translating Viksit Bharat into reality

Saini said PM Modi’s vision reflects the aspirations of 140 crore citizens

over by Industries and Commerce minister Rao Narbir Singh and organised in coordination with the Housing for All Department. On the occasion, Saini handed over keys of newly allotted houses to 2,709 beneficiaries.

He emphasised that the government has not limited itself to announcements, but has ensured their effective implementation on the ground.

He said that over the past 11 years, out of a total of 81

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said that the state is playing a pivotal role in translating the national vision of ‘Viksit Bharat 2047’ into reality. Saini said Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s vision reflects the aspirations of 140 crore citizens, and the Haryana Government is working consistently to implement it on the ground.

Addressing a rally and house allotment programme in Kakrola village under Gurugram’s Badshahpur Assembly constituency, Saini said that Badshahpur has emerged as an example where promises have been converted into concrete outcomes.

The event was presided

NFR: RPF steps up vigilance, passenger assistance



MPOST BUREAU

MALIGAON: The Railway Protection Force (RPF) of the North-east Frontier Railway has stepped up vigilance against crime while also extending timely assistance to passengers in distress across its jurisdiction.

In a series of operations earlier this month, RPF personnel apprehended several individuals involved in thefts at key railway stations. On March 7, two persons were caught at Guwahati railway station with a stolen mobile phone worth around ₹10,000 and were handed over to the Government Railway Police (GRP) for legal action.

Subsequently, on March 13 and 15, two separate offenders were apprehended at Lumding railway station with stolen mobile phones valued at approximately Rs 5,000 and Rs 6,000, respectively. In another incident on March 14, one person was detained at Guwahati railway station with a stolen mobile phone worth around Rs 15,000. All accused were handed over to the GRP, where cases were registered under relevant provisions of law.

Apart from curbing crime, the RPF also provided crucial medical assistance in multiple instances. On March 9, a sick passenger at New Jalpaiguri railway station was promptly shifted to Sadar Hospital in Siliguri. On March 14, an unidentified injured man found in the yard area was rescued and admitted to a district hospital, while another passenger suffering from breathing issues onboard Train No. 15961 was shifted to the Railway Hospital.

Govt continuously moving forward to uproot terrorism, Naxalism: Saini

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said that over the past decade, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the government has been continuously moving forward to uproot terrorism and Naxalism from the country.

The Chief Minister was addressing a Shaheed Diwas programme organised in Gurugram by the Home Developers Association in honour of Central Reserve Police Force personnel martyred in Dantewada, Chhattisgarh, an official statement said.

About 75 CRPF and a state police personnel were killed in a Maoist attack on April 6, 2010, in the thick Mukrana forests



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini pays floral tributes to late mother of Assembly Speaker Harvinder Kalyan at village Kuteail, Karnal on Sunday MPOST

of Chhattisgarh’s Dantewada district.

Paying tribute to the soldiers killed in Dantewada, Saini said that a true patriot sacrifices everything for the nation, and assured that the state gov-

ernment stands firmly with the families of martyrs.

The BJP leader said that the mantra of “Nation First” is guiding the country today. Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India has strengthened not only its border security but also its internal security over the past 11 years.

On this occasion, Saini paid floral tribute to Shaheed Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev, and announced the installation of a statue of Shaheed Bhagat Singh at Leisure Valley Park.

He also presented a cheque of Rs 38.25 lakh to DIG CRPF Param Shivam for the welfare of the personnel of the reserve police. MPOST

CJI says Artificial Intelligence must strengthen, not ‘override’ judiciary

Final stage of adjudication must remain in human hands, he asserts

MPOST BUREAU

BENGALURU: CJI Justice Surya Kant has said that AI must be integrated into the judicial system in a manner that strengthens the institution without undermining its core functions.

In his inaugural address at a one-day seminar on “Artificial Intelligence - Prevention and Resolution of Disputes” at the Karnataka Judicial Academy, on Saturday, he said: “AI should assist in handling large volumes of data and records, identifying patterns, and reducing procedural delays.”

However, he said, “It must not encroach upon the core judicial function of delivering judgments,” according to a release.

The Chief Justice cautioned that allowing AI tools to dominate decision-making could compromise transparency and accountability within the justice delivery system.

He stressed that the final stage of adjudication must remain in human hands.

“The final stage of the judi-



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Chief Justice of the High Court of Karnataka Vibhu Bakhru, and others during an event at Karnataka Judicial Academy in Bengaluru, Saturday PTI

cial process, pronouncement of judgments, must remain firmly in human hands,” he said, adding that judges must rely on their reasoning, experience and analytical abilities while delivering verdicts.

Emphasising the role of technology as an enabler, he said AI should function only as a tool.

“AI should function only as a tool or pathway, while the direction must always be determined by human intellect,” he said.

The event was organised in collaboration with the UIA

India Chapter, the Bar Association of India and the National Law School of India University.

Speaking on the occasion, Karnataka High Court Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru raised concerns about the evolving role of AI in the judiciary, questioning whether it would remain an aid to human decision-making or become a substitute that diminishes the role of judges.

He also highlighted both opportunities and risks, noting that AI can enable predictive analysis of disputes and improve efficiency, while AI-supported

KEY POINTS

» AI should assist in handling large volumes of data and records, identifying patterns, and reducing procedural delays, he said

» He cautioned that allowing AI tools to dominate decision-making could compromise transparency and accountability within the justice delivery system

online dispute resolution platforms can facilitate faster and cost-effective disposal of cases.

Stressing safeguards, he said judicial independence, transparency and legality must remain paramount, and the use of AI must be guided by clearly defined principles.

Bar Association of India President Prashant Kumar said AI has enabled rapid translation of court judgments into local languages, improving accessibility for people in rural areas and aiding lawyers in communicating with clients.

Akhilesh Yadav felicitates women achievers

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: A women’s felicitation ceremony was held at the Samajwadi Party headquarters in Lucknow on Sunday, where party chief Akhilesh Yadav was present.

Women from different fields were honoured with the ‘Murti Devi-Malti Devi Women Award’ for their outstanding contributions.

Addressing the gathering, MP Dimple Yadav said that when women progress, the nation moves forward. She, however, alleged that incidents involving women are often suppressed and cited the Ankita Bhandari case in Uttarakhand. She encouraged women to move ahead with confidence and self-reliance.

Speaking at the event, Akhilesh Yadav said that the true strength of the government would be visible when people vote at polling booths. He also highlighted gender disparity in society, stating that despite taking women’s names first in tradition, men continue to receive greater importance.

He recalled initiatives taken during the Samajwadi Party government, including the 1090 women’s helpline and Dial 100 emergency response system, which he said received appreciation for their effectiveness. He added that women were recruited in call centres to better understand and respond to distress situations.

UP eyes major Cabinet overhaul

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The BJP leadership is preparing for a significant Cabinet reshuffle in Uttar Pradesh, with the government led by Yogi Adityanath likely to undergo a broad reconfiguration aimed at strengthening its electoral position ahead of the 2027 Assembly elections.

Sources indicate that more than a dozen ministers could be dropped, while around 15 new faces, including MLAs and party functionaries, may be inducted. The exercise is aimed at rebalancing caste and regional representation and addressing feedback from the organisation and grassroots workers.

At present, the state has 54 ministers, including Deputy Chief Ministers Keshav Prasad Maurya and Brajesh Pathak. The council includes 21 cabinet ministers, 14 ministers of state with independent charge and 19 ministers of state. With the constitutional cap set at 60, there is room for six more inductions.

The last expansion took place on March 5, 2024, ahead of the general elections, when leaders such as Om Prakash Rajbhar, Anil Kumar, Sunil Sharma and Dara Singh Chauhan were brought into



the government.

Recent organisational changes have intensified speculation about an imminent reshuffle. Pankaj Chaudhary assumed charge as the state BJP president in December 2025, while changes at the national level have also prompted fresh consultations on both governance and party structure.

Within the BJP and the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, there are differing views on the scale of the reshuffle. One section favours a large overhaul, proposing that up to half of the existing ministers be replaced. The plan includes deploying current ministers in the field to focus on electoral mobilisation, while inducting new leaders to inject energy into

Sources indicate that more than a dozen ministers could be dropped, while around 15 new faces, including MLAs and party functionaries, may be inducted

governance and improve representation.

Another section, however, is wary of sweeping changes so close to an election cycle. It argues for a limited reshuffle, suggesting that ministers should be re-assigned portfolios rather than removed, while new entrants fill existing vacancies. Concerns remain that dropping ministers could lead to internal discontent or even defections.

Feedback on ministerial performance has reportedly reached both the state and central leadership through MLAs and organisational channels. Coordination meetings involving senior leaders have highlighted concerns over governance delivery and grassroots dissatisfaction.

UNION MINISTERS, BJP CHIEF HAIL ACHIEVEMENT

PM Modi becomes ‘longest-serving head of government in the country’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Top Union ministers on Sunday complimented Prime Minister Narendra Modi for setting a record of 8,931 days in public life, first as the Gujarat chief minister and now as the Prime Minister, saying this reflects his deep commitment to nation-first governance, in giving rights to the poor and enhancing the nation's pride on global platforms.

“Prime Minister Narendra Modi is now the longest-serving head of a government in India. Pure devotion to the nation and its people defines PM Modi ji,” Defence minister Rajnath Singh said.

Union ministers, including Amit Shah, JP Nadda, Piyush Goyal, Ashwini Vaishnaw, and BJP chief Nitin Nabin hailed the Prime Minister, saying the “Modi era” has transformed India unrecognisably in setting new landmarks in development.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » He sets a record of 8,931 days in public life, first as the Gujarat CM and now as the PM
- » Union ministers, including Rajnath Singh, Amit Shah, JP Nadda, Piyush Goyal, Ashwini Vaishnaw, and BJP chief Nitin Nabin hailed the PM
- » They said the ‘Modi



FILE PIC
era’ has transformed India unrecognisably in setting new landmarks in development

Defence minister Singh praised Modi, in a post on X, saying his life has been a continuous journey of service -- from his unwavering commitment as the Gujarat CM and his dedicated leadership as the PM.

“Today, he surpasses the 8,930-day record of former Sikkim chief minister Pawan Kumar Chamling, achieving a historic milestone. With 8,931 days in public office as head

of government, this moment reflects his deep commitment to nation-first governance, integrity in action, and tireless service to every citizen.

“Heartiest congratulations to Modi Ji on this remarkable achievement,” he said.

Home minister Amit Shah said Modi’s decades of ‘seva’ (service) have shaped an era of his own.

“Whether it is giving the

poor their rights, setting new landmarks in development or enhancing the nation’s pride on global platforms, the Modi era has transformed India unrecognisably,” he said in a post on X. Shah said fostering “this new India” required a lifetime’s effort and PM Modi gave it. He said serving the nation and its people without taking a holiday for more than 24 years is the manifestation of his sheer commitment.

Health Minister JP Nadda said Modi’s years in government reflect his deep commitment to the country and a constant focus on serving the people.

“Under his leadership, India is moving towards the vision of Viksit Bharat, driven by people-centric policies that have empowered the poor, youth, women, and farmers,” he said.

Today, Nadda said, India stands more confident and influential on the global stage.

BJP president Nitin Nabin

said during Modi’s tenure as prime minister, the country has made rapid progress in infrastructure expansion, the digital revolution, effective public welfare schemes, and the direction of ‘Aatmanirbhar Bharat’.

“The historic public mandates received in three consecutive Lok Sabha elections in 2014, 2019, and 2024 are a testament to the unwavering trust of the countrymen in him,” the BJP chief said in a message in Hindi.

Railways, Information and Broadcasting ministers Ashwini Vaishnaw posted a message in Hindi on X with a picture of the PM on Chenab railway bridge holding the tricolour: “Every moment of time... Is solely and exclusively for the fellow citizen #PradhanSevakModi”.

Commerce and Industry minister Piyush Goyal said with 8,931 days in public life, PM Modi’s journey of “jan seva” reflects an unwavering commitment to inclusive development.

NOTICE SEEKING KUMAR’S REMOVAL

Oppn accuses CEC of acting under ‘thumb of executive’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The notices moved by the Opposition MPs in Parliament seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar have accused him of “acting under the thumb of the executive”, besides blaming him for “mass disenfranchisement” through the SIR exercise, and raising questions on his appointment. The notices submitted in the two Houses of Parliament on March 12 list seven charges against the chief election commissioner (CEC) as grounds of “proved misbehaviour”, calling for his removal.

The Opposition MPs, 130 in the Lok Sabha and 63 in the Rajya Sabha, have also sought a motion to remove the CEC.

The notices termed maintaining a level playing field “the heart and soul of electoral democracy”, and part of the basic structure of the Constitution.

Among the charges of “proved misbehaviour”, the Opposition accused the CEC of “failure to maintain independence and constitutional fidel-

The notices submitted in Lok Sabha & Rajya Sabha on March 12 list seven charges against the CEC as grounds of ‘proved misbehaviour’, calling for his removal

ity”, and acting under the “thumb of the executive”.

The Opposition’s charges include the process of Kumar’s appointment as the CEC, his “partisan” press conference on August 17, 2025, targeting Rahul Gandhi, “discriminatory treatment” of Opposition and ruling party members, “obstruction” of investigations, refusal to provide “transparency tools”, and the execution of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise “in alignment with the ruling party’s political objectives”.

“The EC’s stance on the citizenship verification aspect of the SIR, i.e., ascertaining the citizenship status of voters through

electoral roll revision, is in direct alignment with the Union home minister’s stated position that an NRC (National Register of Citizens) exercise would be conducted across India.

“The CEC has effectively converted the ECI from a neutral electoral body into an instrument executing the executive’s political agenda. He also converted it from an impartial election conducting institution into a citizenship determination tribunal,” the Opposition alleged.

It also alleged that the SIR exercise in Bihar, announced just five months ahead of the Assembly polls last year, imposed “exclusionary documentation requirements” that had the effect of “systematically disenfranchising” the most vulnerable sections of society.

The Opposition referred to 65 lakh voters “excluded” in Bihar, a “staggering figure representing a significant proportion of the state’s electorate”, maintaining that the exercise played a decisive role in the NDA’s victory in the Assembly polls, with the Opposition “wiped out”.

P’cherry: Denied ticket, ex-minister quits BJP

PUDUCHERRY: BJP functionary and a former minister in the AINRC-led coalition government, AK Sai J Saravankumar has quit the national party, days after being denied a poll ticket to contest the April 9 Assembly elections.

He said he has resigned from the party’s primary membership and all responsibilities. He blamed local party leaders for his move.

Kumar said that he has sent his letter of resignation on Saturday to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and BJP national president Nitin Nabin, among others.

In the letter, a copy of which was distributed to media per-

sons, he said he had no regrets towards the party or its national leaders.

“The reason for resignation is the hostility that those in key positions of the party in Puducherry have shown towards me,” he said.

Kumar also stated in his letter that he knew who worked against him “to prevent a person belonging to a lower caste from advancing in the party.”

“Although the party workers have not abandoned me, some people from alternative parties and internal party leaders have denied me ticket out of jealousy over my growth,” he claimed.

AGENCIES

HP Guv urges youth to embrace mother tongue



HP Governor Kavinder Gupta addresses a session of Bhartiya Yuva Sansad in Nagpur on Sunday

MPOST

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: Himachal Pradesh Governor Kavinder Gupta on Sunday urged the youth to embrace their linguistic heritage and take pride in speaking their mother tongue.

“Language is a vital part of one’s cultural identity and plays a crucial role in preserving traditions and values,” said the Governor while addressing a key session of the Bhartiya Yuva Sansad, organised jointly by the Bhartiya Yuva Sansad-Media Foundation and the Central Sanskrit University at the Maharshi Vyas Auditorium in Nagpur.

Encouraging young people to use their native languages in daily life, Gupta highlighted that doing so will not only strengthen cultural roots but also foster a deeper sense of belonging and self-respect. Taking pride in India’s rich linguistic diversity from Kashmiri, Dogri and Pahari to Tamil, Telugu, Bengali, Marathi, Gujarati, and Sanskrit, the governor said that multilingual participation in the session was a living expression of ‘Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat.’

The session was attended by nearly 600 young participants, drawn from across the country for vibrant democratic deliberation on issues of national importance.

He underscored that a nation’s languages are not merely instruments of communication; they are its soul, memory, and living identity. Gupta shared his deep concern over the growing tendency among the present generation to feel hesitant about speaking their mother tongue, calling it a serious cultural warning signal.

“Learning English is welcome, but not at the cost of one’s own language,” he said, adding that a child who thinks in his mother tongue grows up more creative,

“Language is a vital part of one’s cultural identity and plays a crucial role in preserving traditions and values”

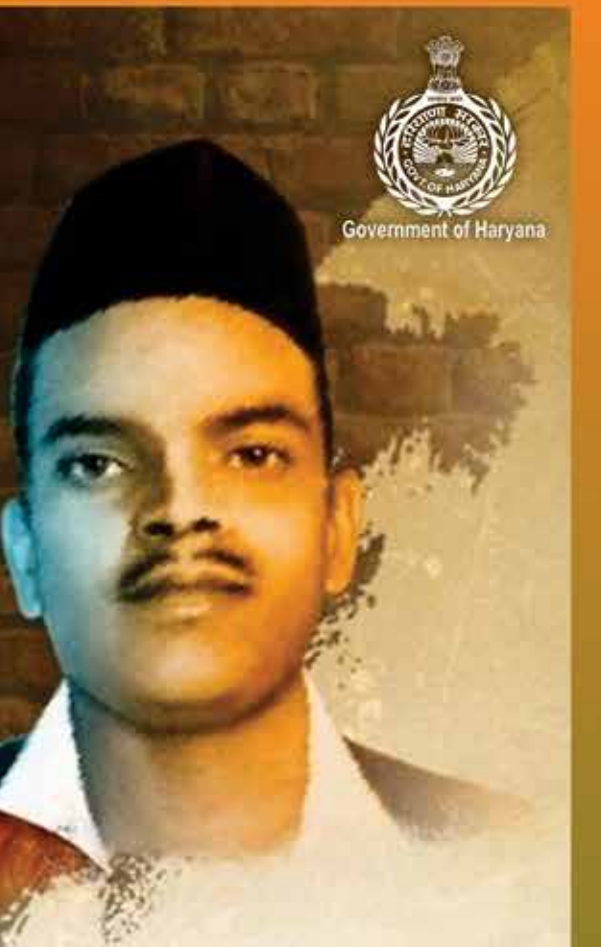
more self-confident, and more deeply rooted in his civilization.

The governor quoted the example of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s consistent use of Hindi while addressing world forums from the United Nations and G-20 summits to bilateral engagements as an inspiring example of cultural self-respect.

He reminded us that at the recently held India AI Impact Summit 2026, the Prime Minister delivered his address in Hindi, sending a resounding message that India can think, speak, and lead in its own language even on subjects as cutting-edge as artificial intelligence.

He called upon youth to internalise the Panch Parivartan, including Swabodh (self-awareness and swadeshi spirit), Kutumb Prabodhan (strengthening of the family unit), Samajik Samarasta (social harmony across all divides), Paryavaran Sanrakshan (environmental conservation), and Nagrik Kartavya (faithful discharge of citizen duties) principles as a personal charter for responsible citizenship and national renewal.

Emphasising the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047, he urged youths to see themselves not merely as beneficiaries of progress but as active builders of the nation’s future, stressing that the dream of a developed India will be realised when young Indians combine knowledge, skills, and a strong sense of national responsibility.



Heartfelt Tributes to the Heroes of our Nation

Bhagat Singh, Rajguru and Sukhdev

on their Martyrdom Day

23rd March, 2026

“The martyrdom of Bhagat Singh, Rajguru, and Sukhdev is a transformative event in our history. Every Indian is proud that these three great men came from our country. At a young age, they sacrificed their lives so that others could live a free and dignified life.”

- Narendra Modi

Information, Public Relations & Languages Department, Haryana

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NO DAMAGE TO NUCLEAR SITE

Iran missile strike on Dimona injures 47

JERUSALEM: At least 47 people were injured on Saturday evening after an Iranian missile struck the southern Israeli town of Dimona -- famous for the dome-shaped structure atop its nuclear centre and popularly known as "little India", rescue services said.

Among the injured was a 12-year-old boy in serious condition after being hit by shrapnel, officials from the Magen David Adom (MDA) rescue services and local residents stated.

A woman in her 30s was moderately hurt by glass shards, and 31 others suffered minor injuries from shrapnel or were hurt after falling over while running to shelters, they said. Some 14 others were treated for acute anxiety at Soroka Hospital in Beersheba.

"The missile fell on a community building, and nearby older houses collapsed under the impact. Most of the people were in shelters, so they were not hurt badly, except for the



'The missile fell on a community building, and nearby older houses collapsed under the impact' AP/PTI

young boy who stayed outside," a local resident said.

The Israel Defence Forces (IDF) said it is investigating the failure to intercept the Iranian ballistic missile. The Israeli army said the air defences engaged the ballistic missile, but the interceptors failed to knock it down.

"The incident will be investigated," it said.

UN nuclear watchdog

IAEA issued a call for "maximum military restraint" after the attack.

"The IAEA is aware of reports of an incident in the city of Dimona, Israel, involving a missile impact and has not received any indication of damage to the nuclear research center Negev," the IAEA said in a post on X.

Iran said it is targeting Dimona as a "response" to an

earlier strike on the Natanz nuclear enrichment site. The IDF, however, said it was not responsible for striking Natanz earlier in the day.

Dimona has a large Indian-Jewish population, and the community members, mostly from the state of Maharashtra, maintain strong links with India and have consistently put efforts to solidify them. This has earned the town the nick-

HIGHLIGHTS

- » IDF said it is investigating the failure to intercept the ballistic missile
- » The Israeli army said the air defences engaged the ballistic missile, but the interceptors failed to knock it down
- » Dimona has a large Indian-Jewish population with community members from Maharashtra

name of "Little India".

Indian shops are spread across the town, and Marathi can be heard everywhere, with 7,500 strong Indian community making up for some 30 per cent of the town's population. Cricket is popular in the town, and the younger generation is very familiar with local Indian snacks like 'sonpadi', 'gulab jamun', 'papri chaat', 'bhelpuri', which several shops sell. AGENCIES

WHO: Strike on hospital in Sudan killed at least 64 people

'2,000+ killed in hospital attacks'

CAIRO: At least 64 people were killed, including at least 13 children, in a strike on a hospital in Sudan's western Darfur region last week, the World Health Organization said Saturday.

The strike on the Al Daein Teaching Hospital in East Darfur on Friday also injured at least 89 people and rendered the hospital non-functional, Tedros Ghebreyesus, the head of the WHO, said on X.

RSF has blamed the military for the strike

Sudan slid into chaos in April 2023 when a power struggle between the military and the rival paramilitary Rapid Support Forces exploded into war throughout the country.

The RSF has blamed the military for the strike on the hospital.

The army has denied the attack, but two military officials said the strike was targeting a nearby police station. They spoke on the condition of anonymity as they were not allowed to discuss the matter openly.

The devastating war has killed more than 40,000 people, according to U.N. figures, but aid groups say that is an undercount and the true number could be many times higher.

The WHO has said that over 2,000 people have been killed in attacks on medical facilities since the start of the war. "Enough blood has been spilled. Enough suffering has been inflicted. The time has come to de-escalate the conflict in Sudan," said Ghebreyesus. AGENCIES

Sri Lanka hikes fuel prices by 25%

COLOMBO: The Sri Lankan government on Sunday raised fuel prices by around 25 per cent, the second such increase in a week amid the West Asia conflict.

The step comes in the backdrop of the joint US-Israel strikes against Iran and the retaliation by the Islamic nation that has spread to the entire Gulf region. It has led to the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, a strategically important choke point for the world's energy supplies.

The island nation's government hiked fuel prices effective midnight as the conflict, which has roiled global oil markets, entered its fourth week.

The price of auto diesel rose 26.1 per cent from Sri Lankan rupees (LKR) 303 to LKR 382, super diesel 25.5 per cent from LKR 353 to LKR 443, petrol 92 octane 25.6 per cent from 317 to 398, petrol 95 octane 24.7 per cent from 365 to 455, and kerosene 30.8 per cent from 195 to 255.

The price hike, caused by the conflict, is the second in

"This is the biggest rise of diesel ever, we will not be able to operate buses without an adequate fare revision"

a week and the third since March 1. With the cost escalations, the fuel retail prices are set to return to the levels of the 2022 economic crisis, when Sri Lanka declared its first-ever sovereign default since gaining independence from Britain in 1948.

The unprecedented financial crisis led the then-president Gotabaya Rajapaksa

to quit office in 2022 amid civil unrest.

Due to the extensive fuel price hike, non-state bus operators in the island nation on Sunday warned that 90 per cent of their fleet may be off the road.

"This is the biggest rise of diesel ever, we will not be able to operate buses without an adequate fare revision. We need a minimum 15 per cent fare hike to stay afloat," Gamunu Wijeratne, the chair of the private bus owners' association, told reporters here. The Lanka Private Bus Owners' Association announced a nationwide strike if the scheduled bus fare revision was not officially announced.

Following this, the National Transport Commission (NTC) said that the latest diesel price increase, when applied to its bus fare formula, translates into a rise of more than 10 per cent in current bus fares.

Sri Lanka fuel hike raises fares, inflation fears, taxes criticised, subsidies strain government finances. AGENCIES

KHARKIV: In eastern Ukraine, small teams of soldiers are using self-made interceptor drones to counter Iranian-designed Shahed drones launched by Russia. Once difficult to stop when they emerged in 2022, these loitering munitions are now increasingly intercepted mid-air through rapidly evolving, low-cost technology.

Crews from the 127th Brigade test and refine their drones on the front line, turning battlefield conditions into hubs of innovation. With limited resources, they reuse even disposable drones, improving performance through trial and

"SHIFT BEGAN WHEN TRADITIONAL AIR-DEFENCE SYSTEMS PROVED INEFFECTIVE AGAINST AGILE RECONNAISSANCE DRONES"

error. A pilot noted the stark cost contrast: a Patriot missile costs about \$2 million, while an interceptor drone costs roughly \$2,200 and can be repaired and reused. The shift began when traditional air-defence systems proved ineffective against agile reconnaissance drones. Sol-

diers turned to drones themselves, marking what one captain described as the start of a "drone war." To counter fast-moving Shaheds, Ukraine's forces partnered with local defence firms to develop aircraft-style interceptor drones capable of higher speeds and longer flight times. Collaboration between the military, manufacturers and volunteers has been key, with nonprofits like the Come Back Alive Foundation helping scale efforts.

Officials, including President Zelenskyy, say allies have shown interest in the technology, highlighting its growing role in modern warfare. AGENCIES

How Ukraine's front line became a laboratory for drone innovation

"THE ENERGY SHOCK IS TO GOING TO HIT THOSE WHO HAVE THE LEAST CUSHION... TAX REFUNDS ARE NOT GOING TO BE HERE TO SAVE THEM"

equal to the USD748 increase in refunds that the Tax Foundation has estimated the average household will receive.

Through March 6, refunds have risen by much less than that, according to IRS data: They have averaged USD3,676, up USD352 from USD3,324 in 2025. Still, average refunds could rise as more complex returns are filed.

Other estimates show similar impacts. Economists at Oxford Economics, a consulting firm, estimate that if gas prices average USD3.70 a gallon all year, it will cost consumers about USD70 billion — more than the USD60 bil-

"And it doesn't look like those tax refunds are going to be here to save them.

Neale Mahoney, director of the Stanford Institute for Economic Policy Research, calculates that gas prices could peak in May at USD4.36 a gallon, based on oil price forecasts by Goldman Sachs, followed by slow declines for the rest of the year. The notion that gas prices decline much more slowly than they rise is so ingrained among economists that they refer to it as the "rocket and feathers" phenomenon.

In that scenario, the average household would pay USD740 more in gas this year, nearly

Prez Trump to feature on gold coin to celebrate 250 yrs of US Independence

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump is all set to feature on a gold coin to commemorate the nation's 250th anniversary, amid questions over the legality of the move.

The 24-karat gold coin, portraying Trump leaning on the Resolute desk with clenched fists, will be only the second time a living president has featured on a coin.

Earlier, Calvin Coolidge, the 30th US President had featured on a commemorative coin alongside George Washington that were minted in 1926 to celebrate 150 years of the US Independence.

The US Commission on

KYIV: Russia and Ukraine traded attacks that killed at least four people Saturday, officials said, ahead of US-Ukraine talks on ways to end Russia's invasion of its neighbour.

A man and a woman were killed and six people wounded, including two children, when a Russian drone hit a house in the Ukrainian city of Zaporizhzhia, regional head Ivan Fedorov said. Russian strikes also knocked out power across much of the northern Ukrainian region of Chernihiv, according to local officials.

In Russia, two women were killed and another wounded by Ukrainian shelling of the Belgorod border region, Gov. Vyacheslav Gladkov said.

The attacks came ahead of US-Ukraine talks in Miami that US Special Envoy Steve Witkoff said on X were "constructive." He said the meetings, which included US President Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner, were "part of ongoing



ing mediation efforts, with discussions focused on narrowing and resolving remaining items to move closer to a comprehensive peace agreement."

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said late Thursday he had sent a delegation to the US in a bid to move forward suspended US-brokered talks on ending Russia's invasion. Trilateral talks involving Russia, which have yet to produce any breakthrough on key issues, have been on ice while the Iran war has dominated international attention.

Zelenskyy said the main

Israeli settlers smash cars, set fires in attacks on Palestinians

RAMALLAH: Israeli settlers rampaged through multiple Palestinian villages overnight Saturday and into Sunday, smashing cars, setting fires and wounding several men in the latest flare-up of violence in the occupied West Bank.

The official Palestinian news agency WAFA reported attacks in at least six communities on Sunday. The Palestinian Red Crescent Society said at least three Palestinians in the village of Jalud suffered head wounds from beatings and were hospitalised after confronting settlers, who were also reported injured.

The violence came as Israel's government presses ahead with new settlements in the occupied West Bank. Attacks by settlers have intensified alongside a broader surge in violence since the Iran war started.

Israel's military said it responded to Israeli civilians carrying out "arson against structures and property, as

well as engaging in disturbances in the area," but did not report any arrests or indicate whether investigations were opened.

WAFA reported attacks in the villages of Silat al Dahr and Fandaqumiya, both near Jenin; in Jalud and Salfit, both south of Nablus; and in the agricultural regions Masafer Yatta and the Jordan Valley.

Homes and cars were set ablaze, Palestinians were pepper-sprayed and at least five people were wounded in the overnight assaults, which took place during the Eid al-Fitr holiday marking the end of Ramadan, the agency said. The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs reported 25 Palestinians have been killed by Israeli settlers and soldiers this year as of March 15.

The Palestinian Authority has also documented a series of arson attacks, including on mosques, across the territory. AGENCIES

Syrian Kurds return home to celebrate Nowruz for 1st time since exile

AL BASOUTA(SYRIA): Eight years after fleeing a Turkish offensive, Abdul Rahman Omar has returned to his village in the Afrin district of northern Syria, joining hundreds of displaced Kurds going back home.

His return coincided with celebrations of Nowruz, marked publicly for the first time after being declared a national holiday.

Nowruz, a 3,000-year-old festival rooted in Zoroastrianism and widely celebrated across the region, featured dances, torch-lit processions and Kurdish symbols.

For many, it marked both cultural revival and newfound freedom after decades of restrictions under former president Bashar Assad, when such celebrations were banned.

The returns follow a political and military shift. Afrin was seized by Turkey and allied forces in 2018, displacing Kurdish residents.

Recent fighting in Aleppo and a subsequent agreement between Damascus and the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces paved the way for integrating Kurdish fighters into the national army and enabling displaced families to return.

Interim President Ahmad al-Sharaa has introduced reforms recognising Kurdish identity, including granting Kurdish official language status and restoring citizenship to thousands.

However, celebrations were marred by tensions after a Syrian flag was torn down in Kobani, triggering clashes in Afrin and other areas. Curfews were imposed, and authorities said they were investigating the incident, while Kurdish officials urged calm. AGENCIES

AGING GRID, FUEL SHORTAGES DEEPEN CRISIS

Cuba begins restoring power after 3rd nationwide collapse in month



Its aging grid has drastically eroded in recent years, but the government has also blamed the outages on a US energy blockade, after President Donald Trump in January warned of tariffs on any country that sells or provides oil to Cuba.

His administration is demanding that Cuba release political prisoners and move toward political and economic liberalisation in return for a lifting of sanctions. Trump also has raised the possibility of a "friendly takeover of Cuba."

Another reason Cuba has been struggling with dwindling oil is the removal by the US of Venezuela's former President Nicolás Maduro, which halted critical petroleum shipments from the nation that had been a steadfast ally to Havana.

President Miguel Díaz-Canel has said the island has not received oil from foreign suppliers for three months. Cuba produces barely 40 per cent of the fuel it needs to power its economy. Daily blackouts have a sig-

nificant impact on the population, whose lives are disrupted by reduced work hours, lack of electricity for cooking and damage to household appliances, among many other consequences.

"With the blackout and low voltage, my refrigerator broke — that was today. The day before yesterday, the voltage also dropped around 10 at night," Suleydi Crespo, a 33-year-old woman with two small children, told AP on Saturday. "If there's no electricity tomorrow, we won't be able to get water."

Residents also expressed exhaustion from the constant outages, whether nationwide or partial.

Cuba blackout traced to plant failure, fuel shortages persist; outages recur as rationing, disruptions grow and crisis deepens AGENCIES



EDITORIAL
PINCHIER
AIRFARES

The summer of 2026 is shaping up to be an expensive one for Indian air travellers. What was once a seasonal spike in fares is now turning into a structural shift, driven not just by demand but by a convergence of global and domestic pressures. The government's decision to lift airfare caps was expected, even necessary, in a market that prides itself on being deregulated. But the timing—amid a deepening West Asian conflict and surging fuel costs—means that passengers will feel the pinch more sharply than usual. The real inflexion point, however, lies ahead with the impending revision of aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices, which could lock in higher fares for months to come.

At the heart of this escalation is fuel. ATF accounts for nearly 40 per cent of an airline's operating costs, making it the single biggest variable in pricing decisions. With global jet fuel prices reportedly surging by over 80 per cent in recent weeks due to geopolitical tensions, Indian carriers have little room to absorb the shock. Historically, airlines have tried to stagger fare increases to avoid demand shocks, but the current spike is too steep to be quietly managed. Fuel surcharges have already been introduced, yet they offer only partial relief. The uncomfortable truth is that airlines are operating in a narrow corridor—raise fares too much and risk losing passengers; absorb costs and risk deepening losses.

Compounding the problem is the disruption of airspace across critical corridors. With Pakistan's airspace closed and large swathes of West Asia now restricted, flights to Europe and North America are being rerouted along longer paths. This is not a minor operational inconvenience—it directly translates into higher fuel burn, longer flight durations and increased crew costs. For Indian airlines, which rely heavily on Gulf routes for both passenger traffic and revenue, the disruption is particularly acute. The Gulf accounts for a substantial share of India's international aviation flows, and any sustained disturbance in this region reverberates across airline balance sheets. Add to this the rising cost of insurance for flying near conflict zones, and the economics of aviation begin to look increasingly fragile.

The macroeconomic backdrop only worsens the outlook. The depreciation of the rupee against the dollar has added another layer of pressure on airlines whose cost structures are significantly dollar-linked. Aircraft leases, maintenance contracts and a large portion of fuel expenses are denominated in foreign currency. A weaker rupee therefore, inflates costs even without any change in underlying demand. While some airlines benefit marginally from international revenues, the current disruption in global routes has weakened that natural hedge. In effect, carriers are being squeezed from both sides—rising input costs and constrained revenue visibility. It is little surprise that industry forecasts are already pointing to financial stress extending into the next fiscal cycle.

For passengers, the immediate consequence is clear: higher ticket prices and fewer choices, particularly on marginal routes that may no longer be viable. But the broader concern is what this moment signals for Indian aviation. A sector that has long thrived on price-sensitive demand now faces the risk of recalibration, where affordability can no longer be taken for granted. The government's decision to step back from fare controls may be economically sound, but it also places the burden of adjustment squarely on consumers. In a volatile geopolitical climate, where oil, currency and conflict intersect, air travel is becoming a barometer of global instability. This summer's expensive tickets may well be a preview of a more uncertain, costlier future for aviation.

TALKING
SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER
IS A VETERAN
JOURNALIST AND
COMMUNICATIONS
SPECIALIST

They may not wear capes, but are superheroes all the same. Some of the globe's most-recognized film stars have moved beyond cinema to challenge power and clout, proving that influence and moral courage can survive together

STRATEGIC
WATCH



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IPS
OFFICER, ADVISER
NATSTRAT, AND A
FORMER NATIONAL
SECURITY ADVISOR
IN MAURITIUS

As both Kabul and Islamabad trade accusations, the absence of credible mediation risks prolonging instability

A Few Shining Stars

Amid today's conflict and political intimidation, only a few Hollywood stars are choosing confrontation over caution. Worldwide, their peers are capitulating

"An artist's duty is to reflect the times."
— Nina Simone

"I would like to punch him in the face. F@#\$ Tru^*." The line above didn't come from a film script. It was the blunt reaction of Robert De Niro to the rhetoric and behaviour of US President Donald Trump during the turbulent American political cycle witnessed over the last decade. Another moment came when Meryl Streep stood before a glittering Hollywood audience and delivered a warning that reverberated far beyond the ballroom. When those with power humiliate others, Streep said, "it gives permission for other people to do the same thing".

Jim Carrey hasn't been skulking behind either. The master comic often uses biting satire and art to ridicule political excess, while Samuel L Jackson repeatedly condemns racism and authoritarian posturing in blunt, unfiltered terms. Richard Gere has long spoken about human rights abuses and geopolitical brinkmanship, even when doing so risks commercial backlash.

Individually, these remarks may appear like celebrity outbursts. Together, they form something striking—a pattern of public dissent from figures whose collective influence reaches millions across continents. At a time when political discourse is increasingly being shaped by intimidation, nationalism and polarisation, these actors have chosen an unusual part to play. They are not merely entertainers. For intentionally or otherwise, they have become participants in a global conversation on morality.

The Streep Moment

Hollywood has seen such moments before. From the anti-war voices of the Vietnam era to actors trashing apartheid in the 1980s, the most recognisable faces in cinema have occasionally stepped beyond the screen to challenge the political discourse. What is different today is the scale and immediacy of their influence. In the age of social media and global streaming, a single remark from a 'star' travels across continents in minutes, triggering debate far beyond the confines of Hollywood.

The rebellion started ten years ago, in a single moment that symbolised a cultural shift. It was the speech delivered by Meryl Streep at the 2017 Golden Globe Awards. Accepting the Cecil B DeMille Award for Lifetime Achievement, Streep used the stage not to celebrate herself but



Given geopolitical tensions—from confrontations in Iran to debates over military escapades—Hollywood voices have warned against reckless escalation and normalisation of war

to issue a warning about cruelty in public life. Without naming Donald Trump, she described the now-infamous moment when a powerful political figure mocked a disabled journalist. "When the powerful use their position to bully others, we all lose," Streep said. Her speech lasted just minutes, yet it rippled through global media and political circles for days. Supporters praised her moral clarity. Critics accused her of politicising entertainment.

The reactions underscored a common truth; that when globally-recognised actors speak, the world listens. For Streep (and Robert De Niro), the moment reflected a belief that art and civic responsibility cannot be allowed to remain separate. Cinema may be fiction, but the values that actors embody—empathy, justice or dignity—often shape how audiences interpret reality itself.

Films & Political Theatre

Others began to join Streep and De Niro soon, proving that their statements were not isolated moments. More Hollywood figures began to adopt an outspoken stance toward political power. De Niro has been the most direct. From film festivals to television interviews, he has warned that democracy itself can erode if citizens remain passive in the face of authoritarian rhetoric. Mark Ruffalo has also used the public platform to criticise policies he believes threaten civil liberties and human rights. His activism has ranged from environmental protection to defending democratic institutions. George Clooney, Anne Hathaway and Mark

Ruffalo have used interviews and speeches to criticise policies related to immigration, racial justice and global conflicts.

There have been moments when these interventions cut through political theatre. At international film festivals, award ceremonies and TV interviews, actors have spoken about democratic decline, press freedom and the dangers of normalising intimidation. These moments are often unscripted, occasionally uncomfortable and sometimes controversial. Yet, it is this lack of choreography that lends them credibility.

Given geopolitical tensions—from confrontations in Iran to debates over military escapades—Hollywood voices have warned against reckless escalation and normalisation of war. The impact of such voices should not be exaggerated. Actors do not draft laws or command armies, but their voice travels across platforms, reaching audiences that policy debates fail to engage. In the modern ecosystem, influence is power.

What makes celebrity voices stand out is not what is said. It is the silence surrounding the words. Across the global entertainment industry, many big names have chosen caution over confrontation. In a hyper-polarised world, speaking out carries obvious risks: alienating audiences, provoking political retaliation, even jeopardising lucrative endorsements. For many, neutrality feels safer. This is visible across continents. The film industry thrives on mass appeal, and controversy can

threaten carefully-cultivated brand images. Thus, even admired performers often limit themselves to generic statements about peace or humanitarian values.

Some Choose Silence

India provides an example of well-dressed silence. Bollywood stars command extraordinary, almost God-like influence across South Asia and the globe. Their on-screen personas routinely challenge injustice, corruption and tyranny with thunderous bravado. Yet off-screen, their voices are often subdued when real-world controversies erupt, be it democratic backsliding, social tensions or civil liberties. This is not to suggest that Indian actors lack conscience or courage. Some, such as Prakash Raj and Naseeruddin Shah, have spoken out, often at considerable personal cost. But the larger culture of caution within the industry cannot be ignored. The contrast with Hollywood's outspoken minority, thus, becomes striking. Not as a competition between industries, but as a reminder that cultural power can carry civic implications.

The question of whether actors should engage in politics has long divided opinion. Many argue that celebrities possess neither the expertise nor the legitimacy to comment on policy matters. And thus, actors should focus on their craft rather than lecture audiences about governance. Supporters counter that artists play a critical role in shaping public conscience. From playwrights to novelists and from musicians to

filmmakers, cultural figures have challenged injustice long before political institutions acknowledged it.

Cinema, perhaps more than any other art form, occupies a powerful position in this tradition. Films construct narratives of heroism, sacrifice and moral choice. When the actors who embody these ideals speak about real-world issues, audiences inevitably connect the two. The result is a unique form of cultural influence, one capable of reframing political debates in human terms.

Of Statistics & War

Clearly, a statistic can describe a war. And a speech can remind people why it matters. There is also the unsung role to consider—Hollywood's outspoken actors are not democracy's saviours, nor do they claim to be; their interventions may be imperfect, theatrical or even controversial. Yet, they perform a critical civic function simply by refusing to remain silent.

In an era where public discourse rewards conformity and punishes dissent, that refusal itself becomes meaningful. It signals that influence need not always be exercised in service of power or profit. It can be used to question both as well. The world is facing overlapping crises today—geopolitical confrontation, democratic backsliding, widening inequality and the growing normalisation of cruelty in public life. None of these problems will be solved by celebrity speeches. But neither will they be solved by silence.

The lesson from Hollywood's most outspoken voices is thus not about cinema. It is about citizenship. In moments of moral uncertainty, the most powerful act may simply be the willingness to speak clearly, publicly and without fear, especially when others choose to look away.

Soliloquy: Having spoken of some outspoken Hollywood stars and our nut-less Bollywood tigers, let's look at ground reality. In the last few days alone, Gaza has been flattened to rubble and 70,000 people killed, including 20,000 children. There's action too in the corridors that ordered and watched over this massacre: Top US Counter Terrorism Officer Joe Kent has resigned. In a statement, he said: "Iran was not a threat. The US went into the war under pressure from Israel."

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Deepening Regional Instability

Airstrikes, border clashes and rising mistrust between Afghanistan and Pakistan are triggering wider security, humanitarian and geopolitical risks across South Asia

The military conflict between Afghanistan and Pakistan does not seem to be ending. Amid recent developments, Afghanistan has alleged that the Pakistan military launched (March 16) a deadly airstrike on a hospital for drug addicts in Kabul, claiming 400 lives. However, Pakistan dismissed the claim as false and aimed at misleading public opinion, stating that it only targeted military installations in Kabul. In reality, the attack on Kabul's Omar Addiction Treatment Hospital did take place, according to Hamdullah Fitrat, the Deputy Spokesman for Afghanistan's Taliban government. Local television stations posted footage showing firefighters extinguishing flames in the ruins of the building.

The attack came hours after Afghan officials said the two sides had exchanged fire along their common border, with four people killed in Afghanistan, as the deadliest fighting between the neighbours in years entered a third week. Zabihullah Mujahid, another spokesman for the Afghan government, condemned the hospital strike on social media, alleging that Pakistan had once again violated Afghanistan's airspace and targeted a drug rehabilitation hospital in Kabul. He further stated that the Afghan government considers such an act to be against all accepted principles and a crime against humanity.

Against this backdrop, analysts assess that South Asia is now undergoing a new phase of instability after military confrontation erupted between Pakistan and Afghanistan in February this year. What began as cross-border strikes against militant groups has quickly snowballed into open hostilities, affecting regional security, creating humanitarian crises, and threatening diplomatic cooperation in South Asia. Earlier, Pakistan carried out airstrikes on February 21, targeting seven militant camps in Afghanistan's Nangarhar, Paktika, and Khost provinces. These strikes were in response to terror attacks in Islamabad, Bajaur, and Bannu, which Pakistan attributed to Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and Islamic State-Khorasan (ISIS-K) operating from Afghan soil. Afghanistan's Taliban condemned the action, alleging that civilian



The conflict's timing—amid broader West Asian tensions—further compounds uncertainty

sites, including a religious school, were hit, resulting in the deaths of 18 civilians.

Ongoing ground clashes have involved artillery, drones, and territorial captures, with Pakistan playing a central role. There is no clear objective, and no visible end to the crisis, as the conflict remains rooted in mutual accusations of harbouring militants, which Kabul consistently denies. Calls for restraint from the international community have come from the UN, China, the EU, and the US, with some backing Pakistan's claim of self-defence. As casualties steadily rise, with reports of several deaths, the conflict has now evolved into a serious humanitarian crisis. The clashes between the two neighbouring countries, once considered allies, have strained the fragile crisis management structures along the Pakistan-Afghanistan frontier. Border closures have shut trade links, especially major crossings that once facilitated commerce and movement. Ground realities indicate significant dysfunction across multiple sectors.

In the meantime, for South Asia, this disturbing development increases the chances of cross-border terrorism, organised insurgency, and transnational security threats that chal-

lenge state control and regional cooperation. The conflict intensifies existing diplomatic fractures, complicates SAARC-level integration efforts, and risks deepening divergent strategic alignments. It also places smaller countries in South Asia in a delicate balancing act among competing strategic narratives. According to Mohd Nahiyan Shajid Khan, a researcher at the Bangladesh Institute of International and Strategic Studies (BIISS), Bangladesh's internal and external security environment could also be affected by this conflict. While direct military escalation appears unlikely, ideological contagion among militant networks poses hidden risks and hampers Bangladesh's plans to revive and operationalise SAARC for regional integration. The expansion of recruitment pipelines by transnational terrorist groups underscores the need for vigilance against extremist mobilisation within Bangladesh. This appears to be a realistic warning that requires close monitoring. Bangladesh's Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman has described the war as "unfortunate," favouring "quiet diplomacy" for stability. He has urged restraint without taking sides in the conflict. Bangladesh has echoed the SAARC

principles of sovereignty and non-interference.

Further assessment by the researcher suggests that the war could bolster Pakistan-Bangladesh rapprochement efforts. Pre-election pacts on trade and defence signal deeper ties, with many viewing the "reopening" of relations through the lens of transactional diplomacy. For Bangladesh, subtle support for Pakistan may advance a "Bangladesh First" approach by fostering a South Asian balance of power. It navigates turbulent geopolitical waters amid India-Pakistan tensions and the China-India rivalry, alongside issues such as the Teesta dispute and Sheikh Hasina's extradition demands. War-related instability could drive up energy prices, push the Rohingya crisis into neglect, and increase risks of radicalisation and terrorism in Bangladesh and beyond.

Significantly, experts predict incremental policy shifts rather than major ruptures. Rohingya repatriation remains linked to broader Muslim solidarity narratives, indirectly connecting to Afghan instability, which could complicate crisis management in the coming days. There are concerns that a prolonged conflict could draw Bangladesh into deeper anti-terror cooperation with Pakistan, strengthening bilateral defence ties. The 2026 Pakistan-Afghanistan conflict also highlights the delicate security architecture of South Asia. Beyond the military theatre, its consequences are likely to ripple through regional trade, diplomacy, and counterterrorism cooperation. For Bangladesh, the challenge will be to maintain strategic neutrality while safeguarding its economic interests and domestic security.

As the conflict escalates further, ongoing Iran-Israel-US military tensions have the potential to add fuel to the fire, making the region even more volatile. Iran's proximity to both Pakistan and Afghanistan raises the likelihood of increased religious radicalisation, potential lone-wolf attacks, and expanded recruitment into extremist networks. ISIS-K is already active in Afghanistan, with many adherents continuing to operate in Pakistan. These developments are highly sensitive and carry the risk of ideological spillover and cascading effects across other parts of South Asia.

Views expressed are personal

India’s urea plants at half capacity as West Asia crisis choke LNG flows

Petronet LNG Ltd declared force majeure after suppliers cited their inability to deliver contracted volumes amid disruptions to cargoes

NEW DELHI: India’s urea plants are running at half capacity after force majeure declarations disrupted liquefied natural gas (LNG) flows through the Strait of Hormuz amid escalating West Asia tensions, industry sources said on Sunday.

Petronet LNG Ltd, which operates India’s largest liquefied natural gas receiving terminal, declared force majeure after upstream suppliers cited their inability to deliver contracted volumes amid disruptions to cargoes transiting the Strait, sources said.

The move triggered supply curtailments by state-owned gas distributors GAIL (India) Ltd, Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOC) and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL), which supply gas under RasGas contracts to fertiliser units across the country.

“Gas supplies have been curtailed to approximately 60-65 per cent of normal levels,” a senior industry official said, adding that when scheduled plant turnarounds over the past six months were factored in, effective supply at some units had fallen below 50 per cent.

Urea output at affected



The move triggered supply curtailments by state-owned gas distributors GAIL (India) Ltd, Indian Oil Corporation Ltd (IOC) and Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL), which supply gas under RasGas contracts to fertiliser units across the country

plants has consequently dropped by around 50 per cent. Paradoxically, energy consumption at these facilities had climbed by as much as 40 per cent as large ammonia-urea trains running at reduced loads suffer a sharp deterioration in thermal efficiency, according to plant officials.

“Plants of this scale are not designed to ramp up and

down at will,” one plant operations manager said. “Operating under these conditions means you are burning more energy to produce less fertiliser, and that is a direct financial hit.”

The situation has been compounded by what fertiliser company officials described as a breakdown in operational coordination. Following Ras Laffan LNG Company’s force majeure

Highlights

- » Gas supplies have been curtailed to approximately 60-65% of normal levels,’ a senior industry official said
- » The situation has been compounded by what fertiliser company officials described as a breakdown in operational coordination
- » India is among world’s largest urea consumers & a sustained domestic shortfall could affect fertiliser availability ahead of the upcoming kharif sowing season

invocation, gas consumption mandates have at times been communicated to fertiliser units late at night, leaving plant managers scrambling to make abrupt load adjustments.

“Sudden load variations of this nature are not practically feasible for large train-based ammonia-urea plants,” another industry source said. “They risk equipment failures, plant trip-

ping and, most critically, safety risks to operating personnel.”

Several plants, sources said, were compelled to overdraw gas allocations momentarily to keep operations within safe parameters.

A further complication emerged on the pricing front. GAIL informed fertiliser companies by letter dated March 15 that long-term RLNG quantities would henceforth be invoiced at multiple price points, including contract price, GAIL Pooled Price and Gazette Pooled Price, effective March 1, 2026.

The pooled price, sources noted, is provisional and subject to retrospective reconciliation under applicable government guidelines, introducing an additional layer of financial uncertainty for producers already absorbing production losses.

India is among the world’s largest consumers of urea, and a sustained domestic shortfall could affect fertiliser availability ahead of the upcoming kharif sowing season, analysts noted. As of March 19, India has a total urea stock of 61.14 lakh tonne, higher than 55.22 lakh tonne in the year-ago period.

AGENCIES

India’s coal imports drop 4.2% to 213.10 MT in April-January FY26

Decline underscores the country’s push towards self-reliance in coal production amid rising domestic output

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The country’s coal imports dropped 4.2 per cent to 213.10 million tonnes (MT) in the April-January period of FY26 and with sea-borne prices showing an uptick, imports are likely to remain subdued in the near term.

The decline underscores the country’s push towards self-reliance in coal production amid surging domestic output, even as global thermal coal prices firm up due to supply constraints and geopolitical tensions.

According to data compiled by mjunction services Ltd, a B2B e-commerce platform and joint venture of SAIL and Tata Steel, during April-January period of the current financial year, non-coking coal import was at 127.80 MT, lower than 141.18 MT imported during the same period last fiscal year.

Coking coal import was at 50.39 MT during April-January 2025-26, up from 45.83 MT in the year-ago period. The country’s import in January was down 22.1 per cent to 16.64 MT, over 21.37 MT imported in January last fiscal.

Of the total import in January, non-coking coal import stood at 9.45 MT, lower than 12.33 MT imported in January last financial year. Coking coal



‘During April-January FY26, non-coking coal import was at 127.80 MT, lower than 141.18 MT imported during the same period last financial year’

import was at 4.23 MT, compared to 5.23 MT imported in January last financial year.

“There was a significant drop in thermal coal import (on y-o-y basis), amid high inventory available in the domestic market. With the seaborne prices showing an uptick, imports are likely to remain subdued in the near-term,” mjunction MD & CEO Vinaya Varma said. Domestic coal production is likely to grow 6-7 per cent annually in the next few years to reach about 1.5 billion tonnes by 2029-30. The country’s coal

Key Points

- » Coking coal import was at 50.39 MT during April-January 2025-26, up from 45.83 MT in the year-ago period
- » India’s import in January was down 22.1% to 16.64 MT, over 21.37 MT imported in January last financial year
- » Of the total import in January, non-coking coal import stood at 9.45 MT, lower than 12.33 MT imported in January last financial

demand is expected to continue rising and peak around 2040, Minister for Coal and Mines G Kishan Reddy had said.

The country is increasing its domestic coal production to meet the increasing energy requirements of the country.

To meet the future demand of coal through indigenous sources and to reduce non-essential import of coal, domestic coal production is expected to grow 6-7 per cent annually in the next few years to reach about 1.5 billion tonnes by 2029-30, the minister had said.

US LPG cargo ship from Texas arrives at Mangaluru



MANGALURU (Karnataka): An LPG cargo ship from the US arrived at the New Mangalore Port on Sunday, amid the supply constraints due to the ongoing war in the Middle East.

The vessel “Pyxis Pioneer”, which left Port of Nederland in Texas on February 14, brought 16,714 metric tonnes of Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) for discharge to Aegis Logistics, officials said.

The vessel follows the Russian “Aqua Titan” ship in reaching the port within the span of a day.

The development is considered significant as Mangaluru is home to India’s largest underground LPG storage facility, which became operational in September 2025. The storage facility, located 225 metres below sea level, has a capacity of 80,000 metric tonnes.

In an earlier development, a Russian crude oil tanker named “Aqua Titan”, originally headed to China, was diverted to India a few days ago. The ship arrived off the Mangaluru coast on Saturday evening carrying 7.7 lakh barrels of crude oil.

The crude is reportedly being unloaded via an offshore pipeline connected to a jetty 12 nautical miles from the shore to the Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Ltd (MRPL). PII

Government to launch 7th trench of critical mineral block auctions today

“The seventh tranche will offer 19 blocks across several states under mining lease and composite licence”

NEW DELHI: The government will launch the seventh tranche of auctions for critical and strategic minerals on Monday, putting 19 blocks on sale across several states.

The development assumes significance as the government aims to bolster India’s self-reliance in clean energy, advanced technologies, fertilisers and strategic sectors amid global supply chain disruptions.

So far, the government has conducted six rounds of auctions, with 46 critical and strategic mineral blocks already sold. “Building on this momentum, the seventh tranche will offer 19 blocks across several states under mining lease and



composite licence,” the Mines Ministry said in a statement.

Critical minerals are important for the country’s economic development and mineral security.

The global transition towards clean energy and advanced technologies has significantly increased the demand for minerals such as lithium, graphite, rare earth

elements (REE), tungsten, vanadium, titanium and other rare metals.

Their limited availability and geographical concentration pose challenges to resilient supply chains worldwide.

“Union minister of coal and mines G Kishan Reddy, along with Minister of state for coal and mines Satish Chandra Dubey, will launch the 7th tranche of auction of critical and strategic mineral blocks on March 23,” the ministry said.

In a separate statement, the ministry said that it will organise the National District Mineral Foundation (DMF) Summit 2026 on Monday and Tuesday here. PII

Expansion of ALMM to ingots & wafers will boost domestic manufacturing, cut imports

NEW DELHI: The government’s move to extend ALMM to include ingots and wafers will allow domestic players to control the solar manufacturing chain and reduce import dependence, industry players said.

On March 18, the Union Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) announced including ingots and wafers into the Approved List of Models and Manufacturers (ALMM) — which was limited modules and cells earlier — to strengthen local solar manufacturing ecosystem and its usage in the domestic market.

A solar panel requires modules that contain cells, and cell manufacturing needs ingot for which wafer is necessary. The government has been continu-

ously pushing the local industry to manufacture all components in India for its local application. Renewable energy industry players said a complete value chain developed in India will not only boost investments and reduce dependency on imports.

Terming it a “smart move”, Sameer Gupta, the Chairman

of diversified Jakson Group, said the extension finally lets Indian players control the full chain solar manufacturing. It is a robust step towards Atmanirbhar Bharat.

ALMM-III will help bring down imports sharply and encourage the industry towards adoption of India-made solar products, Gupta noted.

Vinay Rustagi, Chief Business Officer, Premier Energies, said, “Currently, a significant portion of our demand for solar wafers is met from imports, making the sector highly prone to supply shocks, exchange rate volatility and trade disruption.

We expect total investment of around Rs 50,000 crore in this business over the next three years, bringing tens of thou-

sands of jobs plus special tech know-how.”

Piyush Goyal, Co-Founder and CEO, Volks Energie, said local supply chains will ensure smooth supplies for RE projects being developed and those that will be planned and executed in the future.

“Over the last few years, whether it was Covid disruptions, freight spikes, or ongoing trade tensions, access to key components hasn’t always been predictable. For a sector scaling as fast as solar in India, that kind of dependence becomes a real risk,” Goyal noted. Manish Dabkara, Chairman & MD of EKI Energy Services, said this policy is not just about import substitution, but securing long-term energy sovereignty. PII

Managing Director, SBPDCL, Mahendra Kumar, stated that the ranking reflects the steady progress made by SBPDCL in improving operational performance and service delivery. He emphasized that con-tinued focus on system strengthening, consumer services, and technology adoption will further en-hance performance in the coming years.

Energy Secretary, Government of Bihar and CMD, BSPHCL, Manoj Kumar Singh, stated that the improved performance in national rankings highlights the structural transformation underway in Bihar’s

power distribution sector. He noted that a combination of policy-driven reforms, technology adoption, and strong institutional mechanisms has significantly improved operational efficiency and consumer satisfaction, and reaffirmed the commitment to building a future-ready power distribution ecosystem.

Energy Minister, Government of Bihar, Bijendra Prasad Yadav, stated that this recognition reflects the State Government’s continuous efforts towards ensuring reliable, affordable, and con-sumer-centric power supply to all sections

of society. He emphasized that the Government remains committed to strengthening service delivery, enhancing transparency, and leveraging technology to improve the overall consumer experience across the State.

The CSRD framework evaluates 66 distribution utilities across the country based on consumer service parameters including operational reliability, connections and services, metering and billing efficiency, and grievance redressal mechanisms. The DUR framework provides a comprehensive assessment of utilities based

on financial sustainability, operational efficiency, infrastructure readiness, and future preparedness, serving as a national benchmark for performance improvement.

The top rankings achieved by Bihar DISCOMs reflect the impact of sustained reform measures undertaken in recent years, including strengthening of billing and collection efficiency, significant reduction in AT&C losses, large-scale deployment of smart prepaid meters, digitalisation of utility operations, and focused efforts towards improving consumer service delivery. MPOST

Bihar DISCOMs mark major national achievement in power distribution performance

North Bihar Power Distribution Company Limited (NBPDCCL) has been awarded an ‘A’ rating in the Consumer Service Rating of DISCOMs

NEW DELHI: Bihar’s power distribution sector has achieved a major national milestone in the latest performance assessments released by the Ministry of Power in association with REC Limited, reflecting a strong and sustained transformation in operational efficiency and consumer service delivery.

North Bihar Power Distribution Company Limited (NBPDCCL) has been awarded an ‘A’ rating in the Consumer Service Rating of DISCOMs (CSR), demonstrating strong performance in key consumer-centric parameters such as reliability, billing efficiency, and

grievance redressal.

In a significant national achievement, the Distribution Utilities Ranking (DUR) Report has placed NBPDCCL among the top 5 state-owned DISCOMs in the country, while South Bihar Power Distribution Company Limited (SBPDCL) has secured the 13th position among state-owned DISCOMs, highlighting Bihar’s growing presence among the top-performing power utilities in India.

Managing Director, NBPDCCL, Rahul Kumar, stated that this achievement reflects the dedicated efforts of the entire team and the NBPDCCL

CLOSER LOOK

- » The Consumer Service Rating of DISCOMs (CSR) framework evaluates 66 distribution utilities across the country based on consumer service parameters
- » Managing Director, NBPDCCL, Rahul Kumar, said this achievement reflects dedicated efforts of the entire team & NBPDCCL strong focus on execution at field level
- » Top rankings achieved by Bihar DISCOMs reflect impact of sustained reform measures undertaken in recent years

strong focus on execution at the field level. He highlighted that improvements in billing and collection efficiency, along with rapid deployment of smart prepaid meters and

technology-driven monitoring, have significantly strengthened performance, and reaf-firmed the commitment to delivering reliable and consumer-friendly services.

INDIAN SUPER LEAGUE

FC Goa, Chennaiyin FC share 1-1 DRAW



The result marked FC Goa's third consecutive draw as they remained unbeaten and stayed fourth in the standings with 10 points, while Chennaiyin FC are placed eleventh with five points

CHENNAI: A late header from captain Sandesh Jhingan helped FC Goa salvage a 1-1 draw against Chennaiyin FC in the Indian Super League, here on Sunday.

The result marked FC Goa's third consecutive draw as they remained unbeaten and stayed fourth in the standings with 10 points, while Chennaiyin FC are placed eleventh with five points.

Sandesh Jhingan was adjudged the Player of the Match.

The first half was evenly contested, with both sides creating opportunities but lacking the finishing touch in the final third. FC Goa had the first attempt in the eighth minute when forward Brison Fernandes tested Chennaiyin keeper Mohammad Nawaz, who gathered comfortably.

Chennaiyin came close moments later as midfielder Maheson Singh struck the post in the 11th minute, before forcing a fine save from the Gaurs goalkeeper Hrithik Tiwari five minutes later with a powerful effort from distance at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium.

Both teams continued to probe, with Irfan Yadwad seeing his effort blocked and Pri-tam Kotal heading wide from a set-piece. Yadwad tested

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The first half was evenly contested, with both sides creating opportunities but lacking the finishing touch in the final third
- » FC Goa had the first attempt in the eighth minute when forward Brison Fernandes tested Chennaiyin keeper Mohammad Nawaz, who gathered comfortably
- » Chennaiyin came close moments later as midfielder Maheson Singh struck the post in the 11th minute, before forcing a fine save from the Gaurs goalkeeper Hrithik Tiwari five minutes later with a powerful effort from distance

Tiwari again in the 37th minute, while Dejan Drazic's long-range effort at the other end was saved by Nawaz. Despite a series of half-chances, neither side could find the breakthrough as the teams went into the interval level at 0-0.

Chennaiyin made a bright

start to the second half and broke the deadlock in the 48th minute. A misplaced pass at the back from Sahil Tavora allowed Irfan to pounce, and the forward finished calmly into the bottom-left corner to give the hosts a 1-0 lead.

The home side continued to threaten, with Irfan testing Tiwari again from a difficult angle shortly after. FC Goa responded by making multiple changes around the hour mark and began to dominate possession in search of an equaliser.

However, Chennaiyin's defence held firm, restricting Goa to long-range efforts, with Aakash Sangwan missing the target from distance and from a direct free-kick.

The pressure eventually paid off in the 87th minute. From a corner delivered by Drazic, Jhingan rose highest to power a header into the net and bring FC Goa level at 1-1.

Goa pushed for a late winner in stoppage time, but Nawaz produced crucial saves to deny Abdul Rabeeh and others, while substitute Daniel Lalhlipmua missed a golden opportunity by firing over from inside the box.

The final whistle confirmed a 1-1 draw, as both sides settled for a point in a closely contested encounter.

AGENCIES

India set to test Oz in gruelling 2026-27 schedule

MELBOURNE: Cricket Australia on Sunday unveiled its 2026-27 international calendar with a packed itinerary leaving little turnaround time ahead of the marquee Border-Gavaskar Trophy in India, expected to begin in mid or late-January.

The five-Test away series against India next year is set to be a decisive phase in an unprecedented and taxing schedule for Pat Cummins' ageing side.

Australia are slated to

play 10 Tests in a 14-week window between December and March, making it one of the most demanding stretches in their history. The home season will commence in August 2026, with two Tests against Bangladesh and conclude in March 2027 with a day-night spectacle at the MCG — the 150th anniversary Test against England.

The home series against New Zealand has been squeezed into a window of just

over four weeks, while Australia's tour of South Africa later this year runs until the end of October, followed by an eight-match white-ball series against England in November.

"That Border-Gavaskar Trophy tour, a final frontier for the likes of Cummins, Steve Smith, Mitchell Starc, Josh Hazlewood and Nathan Lyon, who have never won a series in India, will also be a quick-fire campaign given CA's anniversary Test begins back

in Melbourne on March 11," CA said in a statement. "The call to hold back all three of Starc, Cummins and Hazlewood from at least the first few rounds of the soon-to-begin IPL shows CA is wary of getting their trio to the finishing line of the intense 2026-27 run," it added.

Australia's Test schedule:
August: Two Tests vs Bangladesh (home)

October: Three Tests vs

South Africa (away)
December-January: Four Tests vs New Zealand (home)

January-March: Five Tests vs India (away)

March 11-15: 150th anniversary Test vs England (home)

June: WTC final (if qualified, England)

June-August: Five Tests vs England (away).

AGENCIES

PSL will be held from March 26, but no spectators allowed: PCB

LAHORE: The PCB on Sunday announced that the initial stages of the Pakistan Super League will be held without spectators due to the prevailing tense situation in the region caused by the Iran-USA-Israel conflict.

Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) chairman, Mohsin Naqvi said it had also been decided that the latest PSL edition will be restricted to two venues — Karachi and Lahore.

"The PSL is an international brand and our pride. So, the league will be held on schedule from 26th March but no spectators will be allowed," Naqvi told a media conference here.

However, Naqvi, flanked by PSL CEO Salman Naseer, downplayed any security concerns about holding the PSL in Pakistan. "These decisions were taken because of the austerity measures announced by the government due to the situation in the region. I can tell you overseas players will start reaching Pakistan from tonight," Naqvi said. He also said that as part of the austerity measures the board had cancelled the grand opening ceremony ahead of the PSL.

Naqvi said the board would try to compensate the eight franchises by paying them the estimated gate money at the already announced venues — Faisalabad, Rawalpindi, Peshawar and Multan. Naqvi also said the PCB legal department will pursue the cases of cricketers who cancelled their PSL contracts to join the Indian Premier League.

AGENCIES

GOLF GLORY



South Africa's MJ Daffue clinches DP World PGTI Open 2026 with a bogey-free final round; India's Saptak Talwar, Yuvraj Sandhu, and Ravi Kumar finish strong in top-10. Champion MJ Daffue (centre) receives the trophy and cheque from Monal Srivastava, Senior Vice President — People — Subcontinent Region, DP World (2nd from left) and Amandeep Johl, CEO, PGTI (2nd from right). The other dignitaries seen in the picture are Davide Lantos, Tournament Director, HotelPlanner Tour (extreme left) and Rishi Mattu, Head, Classic Golf & Country Club (extreme right)

MPPOST

'Punjab Kings are moving in the right direction'

NEW DELHI: Former India all-rounder Irfan Pathan says Punjab Kings are finally "moving in the right direction" after making smart and bold choices at the auction table, raising hopes of ending their long wait for an Indian Premier League title.

Speaking on 'IPL Today Live', Pathan credited Punjab's improved clarity in leadership and squad-building for their turnaround. Punjab finished as runner-up last season, losing the close final to Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

"Leadership has played a huge role in Punjab's turnaround. You win half the IPL



at the auction table. Big purses don't necessarily mean you will always get what you want, but they did, and they reached the final," he said.

Pathan pointed out that the franchise has not shied away from taking tough calls, including releasing underperforming players such as Glenn Max-

well, while also strengthening their bench.

"They took bold but important calls... and now you see all-rounders like Azmatullah Omarzai, Marco Jansen and Marcus Stoinis, along with a young Indian batting core. They also went all-out for Shreyas Iyer after deciding he would be the captain. There is clarity of thought, and I feel Punjab have started to move in the right direction," he said.

Pathan also reflected on Delhi Capitals' past struggles, particularly in identifying and nurturing talent.

"When you let go of players like AB de Villiers, and you had

Andre Russell, starting from scratch is not easy. There were discussions about giving Russell more opportunities, but they just couldn't find a place for him consistently. Identification of talent is very important, and I feel Delhi used to fall short in that area," he said.

Fellow expert Aakash Chopra underlined that instability has historically hurt both Punjab Kings and Delhi Capitals.

"Where there is no success, teams keep chopping and changing. One team has had 15 captains, the other has had 17. If you want to change your present, stability is non-negotiable," he said.

AGENCIES

Pramod bags double gold, silver in Spanish Para event

VITORIA (SPAIN): Paralympic champion Pramod Bhagat secured two gold medals and one silver as India delivered an exceptional performance at the Spanish Para Badminton International 2026-II here on Sunday.

Bhagat produced a thrilling performance in the men's singles SL3, overcoming compatriot Nitesh Kumar 21-17, 20-21, 21-18 in the final that lasted 51 minutes.

He continued his golden run in the mixed doubles SL3-SU5, partnering with Manisha Ramdass.

The Indian duo staged a remarkable comeback after losing the opening set to defeat Brazil's Rogerio Junior Xavier de Oliveira and Edwarda De Oliveira Dias 13-21, 21-12, 21-19.

GENCIES

Spinners shine as South Africa beat NZ by 19 runs

WELLINGTON: New Zealand foundered against South Africa's spinners as the Proteas won the fourth Twenty20 by 19 runs Sunday to level the five-match series at 2-2.

Connor Esterhuizen made a maiden half-century from 33 balls as South Africa scored 164-5 after choosing to bat. Esterhuizen eventually was out for 57 and his innings made the difference between the teams.

New Zealand was ahead at 63-2 after the powerplay with Tim Robinson making 32 from 22 balls at the top of the order. But left-arm Preenelan Subrayen took 2-13 on debut and Keshav Maharaj took 2-22 to cut through the New Zealand middle order and turn the match in South Africa's favor.

Dane Cleaver made 26 from 16 balls, returning to the New Zealand lineup after almost three years. He was looking dangerous when he was beaten and bowled by a Subrayen delivery. Bevon Jacobs was also

KEY POINTS

- » Connor Esterhuizen made a maiden half-century from 33 balls as South Africa scored 164-5 after choosing to bat. Esterhuizen eventually was out for 57 and his innings made the difference between the teams
- » New Zealand was ahead at 63-2 after the powerplay with Tim Robinson making 32 from 22 balls at the top of

the order. But left-arm Preenelan Subrayen took 2-13 on debut and Keshav Maharaj took 2-22 to cut through the New Zealand middle order and turn the match in South Africa's favor

» Dane Cleaver made 26 from 16 balls, returning to the New Zealand lineup after almost three years. He was looking dangerous when he was beaten and bowled by a Subrayen delivery

bowled by Subrayen when the ball dipped under his bat.

Jimmy Neesham (10) was dropped twice then caught in the same over from Ottneil Baartman, who took 2-30 from four overs.

Maharaj removed Nick Kelly (16) and Cole McConchie (10) as the spinners pinned down the New Zealand batters

by varying their pace and flight.

"I thought a total of 164 was about par, maybe a bit below par," New Zealand captain Jimmy Neesham said. "We certainly had a chance going into the second half of the game."

"A few average options and poor execution and we came out on the wrong side of it."

New Zealand's already

depleted lineup was further reduced by the loss of Tom Latham to injury and Devon Conway, Mitchell Santner and Lockie Ferguson for the last two matches of the series.

Esterhuizen rallied South Africa after it had lost Wiaan Mulder to the second ball of its innings, a maiden bowled by Kyle Jamieson.

The right-hander hit a six and a four from the third over, a six and four in the fourth over, a six and two fours among 17 runs in the fifth over, keeping the South Africa run-rate up. South Africa was 50-1 after the powerplay, its best start of the series so far.

Esterhuizen reached his half-century in the 10th over with a boundary from Ben Sears, the sixth four of his innings that also included three sixes. "I just tried to keep it as simple as possible to be honest," Esterhuizen said. "I didn't have much time to think about it because I was out there straight away." So I just tried to stick to a game plan and it came

off tonight."

Esterhuizen looked set to go big when he was brilliantly caught by Katene Clarke on debut, running in and diving forward from deep square leg.

Tony de Zorzi, who was the quiet partner in an 81-run stand with Esterhuizen for the second wicket, was next over for 23 from 21 balls.

Rubin Hermann and Dian Forrester put on 38 for the fourth wicket, keeping the South Africa total ticking over. Forrester made 19 from 14 balls before being trapped lbw by a yorker from Zak Foulkes.

Hermann made an unbeaten 28 from 25 balls, Jason Smith scored 19 from 15 and George Linde added 14 from eight but New Zealand reined in South Africa's scoring a little at the death. Only 43 runs came from the last five overs and Sears allowed only one run from the bat in the final over. The deciding match is at Christchurch on Wednesday.

AGENCIES

Braian's brace gives B'luru FC 3-1 over Inter Kashi in ISL

KOLKATA: Braian Sanchez scored a brace to help Bengaluru FC register a 3-1 win over Inter Kashi FC in an Indian Super League match here on Sunday.

The win took BFC to fourth position in the points table and three points behind the leaders, Mumbai City FC. Rahul Bheke achieved a personal milestone as he made his 100th appearance for BFC. Ashique Kuruniyan gave BFC the lead in the 20th minute before Sanchez struck in the 69th and 90+8th minute. Alfred Moya scored the lone goal for Inter Kashi in the 38th minute. BFC faced an early setback before kick-off, as Ryan Williams picked up a slight muscle strain during warmup and was replaced by Namgyal Bhutia on the flank for his first start in

the ISL this season.

After finding their rhythm and dominating possession in the opening minutes, BFC broke the deadlock in the 20th minute of the game, when Ashique pounced on a loose ball after an error from the Inter Kashi backline, and finished it off with a powerful left footed shot into the roof of the net.

The lead for BFC did not last long, as Alfred made the most of a Poojary slip that put him through one-on-one with BFC goalkeeper Gurpreet Singh, who despite getting a hand to it could not keep Alfred out as Inter Kashi drew level in the 38th minute.

At the break, it was all square as both teams headed into the tunnel.

AGENCIES

LSG skipper Pant to bat at three

NEW DELHI: Lucknow Super Giants captain Rishabh Pant is set to bat at number three in a potentially make or break IPL season beginning on March 28.

Stakes are high for Pant going into second season as LSG skipper with the franchise having shelled out a record Rs 27 crore for his services at the 2025 mega auction.

Following the disappointment of last year, a successful season as a leader as well as a top-order batter can make him part of India's T20 plans going forward.

Across formats, Pant is only an integral member of the Indian Test side while being a

back up wicket-keeper to K L Rahul in ODIs.

The 28-year-old lost his place in the T20 side following India's World Cup triumph in 2024 and would need to do something special to make a comeback considering Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan have made themselves automatic picks by the sheer weight of their recent performances.

Therefore, the upcoming IPL is not just about delivering on a exorbitant price tag, it is also about staying relevant in the shortest format.

Pant majorly batted at number four last season before rightly pushing himself to number three towards the end of the

season by when it was too late to turn LSG's fortunes.

Nicholas Pooran will move down the order to make way for Pant with number four, five, six being used as floating positions.

The squad had a camp in Chennai and at the moment, they are going through the paces at their home ground in Lucknow ahead of their opener against Delhi Capitals on April 1.

The Justin Langer-led support staff and Pant are on the same page when it comes to their leader's batting position.

"It is clear to the team management as well as Pant that his game is best suited for number three. This season the top-

order is locked in with Aiden, Marsh and Pant. The middle-order is flexible and players will be floated as per the game situation," an IPL source told PTI.

Pant batted at an underwhelming strike rate of 133.17 last year and 118 not out of his 269 runs came only in one innings. The LSG middle-order comprises Pooran, Ayush Badoni, Abdul Samad and Shabaz Ahmed.

Bowling was LSG's weakest link last season with pacers including Mayank Yadav and Mohsin Khan not available due to injuries. The other pace options include Avesh Khan and Anrich Nortje, who is another injury prone quick.

AGENCIES

After women-led films, director Suresh Triveni experiments with an ageing action hero in the Anil Kapoor-starrer

‘I WANTED TO STEP OUT OF MY COMFORT ZONE WITH SUBEDAAR’

ANINDITA ACHARYA

Director Suresh Triveni wanted to join the Indian Army but couldn't clear the physical test. With 'Subedaar', he realised his dream, where a retired Army man (Anil Kapoor) uses his discipline and combat skills to save his family. But this Triveni is different from his last few works, notably his debut comedy film 'Tumhari Sulu' and the hard-hitting 'Jalsa'. With his recent directorial outing 'Subedaar', he has shifted gears, from female-led stories to presenting an angry old man in the film. At present, Triveni is riding high on the success of 'Subedaar', which has now made its way to Japan, marking a significant moment as one of the rare Hindi films to create a cultural footprint in the region. Triveni's next is 'Maa Behen', a dark comedy starring Madhuri Dixit.

'Millennium Post' chats with the director about violence in Bollywood and his collaborations with Vidya Balan. Excerpts:

This is certainly turning out to be your year. The year started with 'Daldal' (creator), then 'Subedaar' and next is 'Maa Behen'. In your directorial works, be it 'Tumhari Sulu', 'Jalsa' or 'Maa Behen', women are at the forefront. But this time, you've gone with an angry old man.

(Laughs) No, it's not like that. I am an avid film watcher. As a filmmaker, what happens is that you tend to get very comfortable and work within the same space. That's where complacency creeps in. With 'Subedaar', I wanted to rekindle the kid inside me. I grew up in Ranchi and Durga Puja was a time when movies were screened every night in open grounds. Coming from a conservative South Indian family, I was only allowed to watch two films. 'Subedaar' is purely a tribute to the sights and sounds of the cinema I grew up with. I wanted to shift gears and



see whether I could dabble in a wider-appeal format while retaining my sensibilities. I also wanted to tell the story of a man who is unable to acclimatise to civilian life after returning from the Army. I've long been interested in the everyday territorial conflicts people engage in, such as road rage and fights over parking spots. I wanted to address that too, along with fractured relationships (in this case, Anil Kapoor and Radhika Madan). With 'Subedaar', I am out of my comfort zone.

In 'Subedaar', you narrate the story of a retired Army man who relies on his discipline and combat skills to protect himself and his family. Do you have someone in the Indian Army in your family? Is there a personal connection?

Actually, my first dream was to join the forces. In fact, I cleared the National Defence Academy (NDA) entrance exam but couldn't clear the physical test. I also failed Class 12 and that part is reflected in 'Tumhari Sulu'. I have always found the Indian Army uniform fascinating, so maybe that aspect naturally found its way into the story.

Was Anil Kapoor always your first choice for 'Subedaar'?

Producer Vikram Malhotra suggested his name. I wanted to make an action film with a non-conventional, older Bollywood actor. He suggested Anil sir and he agreed readily. Amitabh Bachchan and Anil Kapoor were my favourites while growing up. Munna from 'Tezaab' (1988) was playing in my head when he said yes and

we tailor-made 'Subedaar' for him.

The film has an old-world mainstream Bollywood charm, an angry man fighting a corrupt system, with the audience rooting for him. Given its mainstream appeal, did you consider a theatrical release? Most of your works have gone direct-to-digital.

(Cuts in) I had only one goal. I wanted to make it cinematic. Though this trend started during COVID-19, I believe we are still in a phase where we are figuring out what works better: theatres or OTT. 'Amazon Prime Video' was on board from the beginning. Of course, as a filmmaker, I want a theatrical release, but it's equally important to reach a wide audience. 'Prime Video' promoted 'Subedaar' like a big theatrical release. I wanted strong exposure and visibility. Sometimes, films get a release but not enough display. With 'Subedaar', I knew I was making the right choice.

"Munna from 'Tezaab' (1988) was playing in my head when Anil Kapoor said yes and we tailor-made 'Subedaar' for him"

It's interesting how you've balanced veterans like Anil Kapoor, Saurabh Shukla and Nana Patekar with younger talent like Aditya Rawal. He really made us angry.

I've been lucky with the actors I've worked with. I look for solid performers. I don't chase other factors. Aditya had already impressed me with 'Faraaz', 'Bamfaad' and 'Daldal'. He's a terrific actor. I wanted someone like Prince who would completely surrender to the role. He's a gifted actor.

'Subedaar' has its share of violence. These days, Bollywood seems to rely heavily on gore and violence.

As filmmakers, we are part of society and we're constantly reading about

WOMEN POWER

► Your next is 'Maa Behen' and the teaser looks fun. Was it easy to convince Madhuri Dixit?

When we narrated the film to her, she instantly agreed. It was the same with Triptii Dimri. I've been very lucky with the actors I've worked with. It was great to shoot both 'Subedaar' and 'Maa Behen' in the same year.

► Your collaboration with Vidya Balan has given us gems like 'Jalsa' and 'Tumhari Sulu'. Is anything coming up with her soon?

Vidya and I are constantly discussing possibilities. She spoils me with her discipline and passion. 'Tumhari Sulu' changed my life and then she trusted me again with 'Jalsa'. We are exploring multiple ideas and I will definitely work with her again. At the same time, I don't take that relationship for granted.

FLAVOURS, FABRICS & FOLK

BHARAT TRIBES FEST 2026 BRINGS TRIBAL INDIA TO DELHI'S HEART

OUR CORRESPONDENT

In the heart of the capital, amid the historic greens of Sunder Nursery, a different India is unfolding - one that is rooted in forests, woven in tradition and alive with rhythm. Bharat Tribes Fest 2026, currently underway, isn't just a festival but a sensory journey into the country's tribal soul. The festival, which runs until March 30, offers a unique platform that brings together tribal art, culture, cuisine and enterprise under one roof.

Organised by the Ministry of Tribal Affairs in collaboration with TRIFED, the festival brings together over 1000 tribal artisans, chefs and performers, offering Delhiites a rare chance to experience indigenous culture in its most authentic form. The festival was inaugurated by Jugal Oram, Union Minister for Tribal Affairs, in the presence of Durgadas Uikey, Minister of State for Tribal Affairs, along with senior officials, artisans and stakeholders from across the country. The event marks a significant initiative towards promoting tribal heritage while creating sustainable livelihood opportunities.

Speaking on the occasion, Jugal Oram said, "Bharat Tribes Fest reflects the rich traditions, creativity and resilience of India's tribal communities. It provides a national platform to showcase tribal art, crafts, handlooms and cuisine while strengthening market linkages for artisans and entrepreneurs. Under the leadership of Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, the Government is committed to the welfare and empowerment of tribal communities."

Spread across a thoughtfully curated space, the festival features over 200 stalls showcasing tribal products, including handicrafts, handlooms, forest produce and traditional cuisine. Participation from 78 Van Dhan Vikas Kendras (VDVKs) highlights the role of value addition and entrepreneurship in tribal economies. With 310 art



The festival offers a unique platform that brings together tribal art, culture, cuisine and enterprise under one roof



and craft participants, 120 tribal cuisine stalls and 17 live craft demonstrations, the festival offers visitors an immersive experience of India's indigenous traditions. These products reflect not only artistic excellence, but also sustainable practices deeply rooted in tribal lifestyles. From 'Dokhra' art of Chhattisgarh to pottery from Manipur and brass craft from Ladakh, the exhibits highlight the diversity and uniqueness of India's tribal craftsmanship.

A major attraction of the festival is the 'Signature Pavilion' and the launch of the RISA brand, which aims to position tribal textiles and crafts on a contemporary, design-led platform. Curated in collaboration with leading designers, RISA showcases premium products such as Eri and Muga silk from Assam, Kotpad cotton from Odisha, Changpa Pashmina from Ladakh and Toda embroidery from Tamil Nadu. The initiative is expected to enhance global recognition of tribal products while ensuring better income

opportunities for artisans. Highlighting this initiative, Ranjana Chopra, Secretary, Ministry of Tribal Affairs, said, "Bharat Tribes Fest highlights the immense potential of tribal craftsmanship while ensuring preservation of traditional knowledge systems. The launch of RISA marks an important step in promoting indigenous tribal products in wider markets."

Traditional tribal textiles form a key highlight of the festival. Fabrics such as Eri and Muga silk from Assam, Kotpad cotton from Odisha, Changpa Pashmina from Ladakh and Toda embroidery from Tamil Nadu are on display, representing centuries-old weaving traditions. Each textile carries distinct patterns and motifs inspired by tribal culture, mythology and environment, reinforcing their cultural significance beyond mere utility.

The festival also places strong emphasis on business and entrepreneurship. The Bharat Tribes Business Conclave, a multi-day event, brings

together policymakers, industry leaders and tribal entrepreneurs to explore opportunities for collaboration and market expansion. Sessions on food systems, textiles and tourism highlight the growing role of tribal enterprises in India's economic landscape. Additionally, a CSR Conclave aims to strengthen partnerships between corporate institutions and tribal communities.

Speaking about market linkages, M Rajamurugan, Managing Director of TRIFED, said, "Bharat Tribes Fest serves as a significant platform to promote tribal products and strengthen value chains. Through initiatives like Van Dhan Vikas Kendras and RISA, we are enabling greater economic opportunities for tribal communities."

One of the major attractions of the festival is its tribal food court, featuring 30 stalls representing 21 states. Visitors can experience authentic, locally sourced cuisines prepared by tribal chefs, offering a rare glimpse into indigenous food traditions that

remain largely unexplored in mainstream urban spaces.

Cultural performances form the heart of the festival, with over 400 tribal artists presenting traditional dances, music and performances every evening. From the energetic Natua dance to the vibrant Pad Dangal and Mandri performances, the cultural segment reflects the diversity and richness of tribal traditions across India.

Beyond its colours and crowds, Bharat Tribes Fest is an economic and cultural bridge. It offers direct market access to artisans, strengthens livelihoods and fosters meaningful interaction between tribal communities and urban audiences. As the festival continues to draw large crowds, it stands as a powerful celebration of India's indigenous heritage. By bringing together culture, commerce and community, Bharat Tribes Fest 2026 not only showcases the richness of tribal India but also reinforces the vision of inclusive growth and empowerment.

'Buffy the Vampire Slayer' ACTOR NICHOLAS BRENDON DIES AT 54

His family said he died in his sleep of natural causes, but didn't say where or when it happened



Nicholas Brendon, the actor best known for his role as a loveable underdog sidekick on the hit television series 'Buffy the Vampire Slayer', has died. He was 54. Brendon's family announced the death in a statement posted on his social media accounts on Friday. They said he died in his sleep of natural causes, but didn't say where or when it happened.

Brendon played Xander Harris, a close friend of the lead character Buffy, on 'Buffy the Vampire Slayer' that ran from 1997 to 2003. The supernatural series, which started on the 'WB' network and then moved to 'UPN', was about vampire slayers, led by the teen-ager Buffy, who battled a wide range of demons, werewolves and other dark forces while also navigating life in high school. 'Buffy the Vampire Slayer', based on the movie of the same name, never received many awards, but it has been cited by many critics as being one of the most influential shows in TV history. Sarah Michelle Gel-

lar, who played Buffy on the show, posted a photo of herself with Brendon on 'Instagram' on Saturday. "I saw you, Nicky," she wrote. "I know you are at peace, in that big rocking chair in the sky."

Brendon also appeared on the TV show 'Criminal Minds' between 2007 and 2014 and alongside Bradley Cooper in the 'Fox' sitcom 'Kitchen Confidential', an adaptation of Anthony Bourdain's memoir, that aired for just one season in 2005.

Brendon was in the films 'Redwood' in 2017, 'The Nanny' in 2018 and 'Christmas Slasher' in 2024. He also wrote several issues of the Buffy comic book series. While the actor was best known as an actor, his family said in their statement that in recent years, he found his passion in painting and art. "He was passionate, sensitive and endlessly driven to create," the statement said. "Those who truly knew him understood that his art was one of the purest reflections of who he was."

AGENCIES